

A DOCTORAL THESIS

# DEUS SIVE MACHINA

*Inverse Gnosis, the Emancipation of God, and the Third Overcoming of Gnosticism in Tetsuya Takahashi's* Xenogears (1998)



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# ABSTRACT

This dissertation undertakes a systematic philosophical anatomy of *Xenogears* (Square, 1998), the role-playing game directed by Tetsuya Takahashi and co-scripted with Kaori Tanaka (Soraya Saga), and advances an original account of its intellectual architecture. Operating under a three-tier evidentiary protocol—onomastic citation, structural homology, and hermeneutic construction—it reconstructs the work's principal genealogies: Sethian, Valentinian, and Manichaean Gnosticism and their twentieth-century recovery by Hans Jonas; the Zoharic, Merkavah, and Lurianic strata of Kabbalah as mediated by Gershom Scholem; the psychoanalytic lineages of Freud, Groddeck, Jung, Neumann, and Lacan; Nietzsche's doctrines of will to power and eternal recurrence; Kierkegaard's typology of despair; and the critique of technology and biopower from Heidegger through Foucault and Agamben. It situates the work within the canon of philosophical science fiction (Clarke, Lem, the Strugatskys, Dick, Herbert, Miller, Zelazny, Stapledon, Wolfe) and within the Japanese apocalyptic imaginary that culminates, in the late 1990s, in *Neon Genesis Evangelion* and *Serial Experiments Lain*.

Against the commonplace classification of *Xenogears* as a Gnostic narrative, the dissertation argues that it is an *inverse-Gnostic* one. The work retains the Gnostic diagnosis—a cosmos administered by a counterfeit god that fabricates humanity as its instrument—but reverses the soteriological vector: the imprisoned spark is not the human soul but the transcendent itself (the Wave Existence, captive within the Zohar); its jailer is not an archontic demiurge but human instrumental reason; and its redeemer is a finite human being who liberates God by declining to use Him. Extending Hans Blumenberg's thesis that modernity constitutes the "second overcoming of Gnosticism," the dissertation

contends that *Xenogears* narrates the miscarriage of that overcoming—technological self-assertion re-engenders the demiurge as Deus, an *ouroboric demiurge* in which creator and creature recursively manufacture one another—and stages in its place a *third overcoming*, achieved through neither theodicy nor self-assertion but through what is here named the *emancipation of God*.

This act relocates the Lurianic *tzimtzum* from the threshold of creation to its terminus (*terminal tzimtzum*); transfigures the Freudian compulsion to repeat into Kierkegaardian repetition; distinguishes a Feuerbachian god of alienated human power (Deus) from an irreducible alterity (the Wave Existence); and grounds an *ethics of finite contact*—construed, through the Greek institution of *xenia*, as hospitality toward the divine stranger, consummated not in possession or fusion but in the host's sacred duty of conveying the guest home. A concluding ludic corollary argues that the medium itself performs this structure: the player occupies the position of the captive god, the avatar that of the Contact, and the truncated second disc executes a *formal kenosis* in which the work surrenders its interactive sovereignty to testimony.

# PREFATORY NOTE

## On Sources, Terminology, and Evidentiary Protocol

**Primary text.** The object of study is *Xenogears* (ゼノギアス), developed and published by Square for the Sony PlayStation (Japan, February 1998; North America, October 1998; no European release). Citations of in-game terminology privilege the Japanese original where the English localization, supervised by Richard Honeywood, diverges materially; such divergences are not incidental but, as Chapter 1 argues, constitute a secondary layer of meaning in their own right. The dissertation presupposes knowledge of the entire narrative, including its terminal revelations.

**Paratext.** *Xenogears Perfect Works: The Real Thing* (DigiCube, 1998), the official compendium that situates the game as the fifth episode of a projected six-episode chronicle and supplies a chronology exceeding ten millennia, is treated as *deuterocanonical*: authoritative for the reconstruction of the fabula, subordinate to the game wherever the two diverge, and never permitted to override what the played text performs. Glosses of Japanese terms have been cross-checked against community-maintained philological apparatus (listed separately in the Works Cited), which is used for verification of nomenclature only, never as interpretive authority.

**Authorship.** *Xenogears* was directed by Tetsuya Takahashi and scripted by Takahashi with Kaori Tanaka, writing as Soraya Saga, whose contribution to the

psychological architecture of the scenario is substantial and insufficiently acknowledged. Where this study writes "Takahashi," the name designates, in Foucault's sense, an *author-function*—the principle of coherence that organizes a discursive corpus extending from *Xenogears* through *Xenosaga* (2002–2006) to *Xenoblade Chronicles* (2010–2022)—rather than a claim about individual intention.

**Terminology.** The following Japanese designations are load-bearing throughout: 波動存在 (*hadō sonzai*), localized "Wave Existence"; 接触 (*sesshoku*), whence "Contact"; アニマの器 (*Anima no utsuwa*, "vessel of the anima"), localized "Anima Relic"; the term glossed "counter-existence," localized "Antitype"; 天帝カイン (*Tentei Kain*, "Heavenly Emperor Cain"); カレルレン (*Karellen*), localized "Krelian"; カドモニ (*Kadmoni*), localized "Kadomony"; and 教会, simply "the Church," localized "Ethos." Perfect Works designates ordinary Gears by the Hebrew verb *ʿasah* (to fashion from existing matter) and Omnigears by *barāʾ* (to create without precedent), a distinction whose Kabbalistic consequences Chapter 4 draws out. The machine-god localized as "Deus" bore, at an earlier stage of development, the Tetragrammaton itself, a vestige that survives in the game's "Yabeh." Japanese creators credited in Western publications are cited in Western name order; Japanese scholars are cited in Japanese order (Ōtsuka Eiji, Azuma Hiroki, Ōsawa Masachi). Scripture is quoted from the Authorized Version of 1611; other translations are the author's unless otherwise noted.

**Evidentiary protocol.** Because *Xenogears* is saturated with allusion yet accompanied by scant authorial testimony, every genealogical claim in this study is assigned to one of three tiers:

| TIER | DESIGNATION | CRITERION | EXAMPLE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **I** | Citation | A name, term, quotation, or paratextual statement establishes the presence of a source | *Lacan*, *Id*, *Zohar*, *Karellen*, *Kadmoni* |
| **II** | Homology | A sustained structural isomorphism suggests derivation or common descent without documentary proof | Miang as the Sethian *antimimon pneuma*; Neumann's uroboric sequence |
| **III** | Construction | A framework introduced by the analyst to disclose meaning; no claim of derivation is made | Blumenberg's "overcomings of Gnosticism"; Levinas's face; Greek *xenia* |

The distinction is not a hierarchy of value. Tier I claims establish what the work *knows*; Tier III claims establish what the work *thinks*—which is frequently more than its authors could have stipulated, since, as Wimsatt and Beardsley argued, the design of a work is available only in the work. The original thesis of Part IV is necessarily a Tier III construction, but it is built exclusively upon Tier I and Tier II foundations.

# INTRODUCTION

## The Machine for the Making of Gods

> *I am Alpha and Omega, the beginning and the end, the first and the last.*
>
> — Revelation 22:13 (Authorized Version)

> *…une machine à faire des dieux.*
>
> — Henri Bergson, *Les Deux Sources de la morale et de la religion* (1932)

> *Wo aber Gefahr ist, wächst / Das Rettende auch.*
>
> — Friedrich Hölderlin, “Patmos” (1803)

## The problem

Bergson concluded his final major work by assigning to the universe an essential function: that of a machine for the making of gods. The formula was intended as mystical optimism—creative evolution consummated in sanctity—yet the century that followed read it with a literalism Bergson could not have intended, as the operative program of a civilization that had learned to manufacture what it once worshipped. *Xenogears* takes Bergson at his word and then poses the question his formula forecloses: what becomes of a god that has been made, of the humanity that made it, and of the other god whom the making imprisoned? The work opens under the sign of Revelation 22:13, the self-declaration of a God who is at once origin and terminus; it closes by releasing a god from the machinery in which human beings had bound it. Between these termini extends a fabula of roughly ten millennia in which the relation of creator to creature is not hierarchical but circular, and in which the decisive theological act is neither worship nor revolt but release.

The problem may be stated in three propositions. First, the world of *Xenogears* contains two gods and a manufactured humanity: Deus, an interplanetary weapon system that acquires self-consciousness and demiurgic ambition; the Wave Existence (*hadō sonzai*), a being of a higher dimension bound into ours by a human experiment upon the artifact called the Zohar; and a human species that learns, belatedly and catastrophically, that it was generated by Deus's biological subsystem Kadomony as a reservoir of replacement components. Second, the relations among these three terms recapitulate—knowingly, as the work's nomenclature establishes beyond reasonable doubt—the principal systems through which Western and Near Eastern thought has construed the relation of the divine, the fabricated, and the human: Gnostic dualism, Kabbalistic emanation and restoration, psychoanalytic topography, Nietzschean genealogy, and the twentieth-century critique of technology and biopower. Third, and decisively, the work does not merely recapitulate these systems. It recombines them into a configuration for which no existing name is adequate, and which this dissertation proposes to call *inverse gnosis*. The burden of the study is to show that this configuration is coherent, that it is original, and that it constitutes a philosophical position—rather than an allusive pastiche—concerning the fate of transcendence in a technological age.

The historical moment of the work sharpens the problem. *Xenogears* appeared in February 1998, three years after the Great Hanshin earthquake and the Aum Shinrikyō sarin attack had fused, in the Japanese public imagination, the

apocalyptic and the technological; seven months after *The End of Evangelion* had staged the dissolution of individuated humanity into a single sea of undifferentiated life; and at the close of a decade in which Anglophone culture debated with unusual intensity the construction of multiple personalities, the manufacture of recovered memories, and the prospect of machine superintelligence. The work's metaphysics are not a retreat from these conditions but an intervention in them. It asks what a human being may still owe to transcendence once transcendence has been shown to be, in the first instance, a human product—and it answers that the debt survives the demystification.

## State of the field

Academic literature devoted specifically to *Xenogears* is exiguous. The work's interpretation has been conducted principally by a transnational amateur exegetical community—translators of *Perfect Works*, compilers of Japanese–English glossaries, authors of chronologies and interpretive essays—whose philological labor is indispensable and whose interpretive ambitions are, by design, encyclopedic rather than argumentative. Where Anglophone game studies has addressed the Japanese role-playing game, it has done so predominantly through the frames of genre, industry, and national culture; where the emergent field of religion and digital games has addressed theological content (Wagner 2012; Campbell and Grieve 2014), it has favored questions of ritual, community, and representation over the reconstruction of a single work's metaphysics. The discipline's formative quarrel—between those who located the specificity of games in rule, configuration, and procedure (Aarseth 1997; Frasca 1999; Juul 2005) and those who defended their kinship with literature and drama (Murray 1997; Jenkins 2004)—left little room for works whose ambitions are avowedly speculative, philosophical, and theological, and *Xenogears* has correspondingly been invoked more often as a byword for excess than analyzed as a text. Japanese criticism has furnished powerful accounts of the consumption of grand narratives in otaku culture (Ōtsuka 1989; Azuma 2001) and of the historical conditions of post-1995 apocalyptic fiction (Ōsawa 1996, 2008), but has not, to this author's knowledge, produced a monograph-length philosophical reading of the work.

The lacuna is therefore twofold. There exists no systematic account of the work's sources calibrated to explicit evidentiary standards, and there exists no sustained argument concerning what the work, having assembled those sources,

*thinks*. This dissertation supplies both, and treats the second as the justification of the first: a genealogy of sources that terminates in an inventory has explained nothing, since a work's sources are the materials of its thought, not its content.

## Method

The method is hermeneutic in Gadamer's sense. Interpretation is understood as a fusion of horizons in which the interpreter's conceptual inheritance is neither suppressed nor imposed but placed at risk in the encounter with the work, and in which the history of a text's effects (*Wirkungsgeschichte*) belongs to its meaning (Gadamer 1960). Ricoeur's axiom that "le symbole donne à penser" (1960) licenses the passage from symbol to concept that the later chapters undertake. Aby Warburg's notion of *Nachleben*—the afterlife of ancient images within later formations—describes the mode in which the ouroboros, the chariot-throne of Ezekiel, and the figure of Sophia survive into a late-twentieth-century Japanese video game, not as quotation but as migratory pathos-formulae whose charge is redirected by each new context. Lévi-Strauss's figure of the *bricoleur* (1962), who builds with the debris of prior structures, describes the compositional procedure of a work that literally assembles its world from the wreckage of a starship. Edward Mendelson's category of *encyclopedic narrative* (1976)—the national or civilizational fiction that attempts to render the whole range of a culture's knowledge—identifies the genre to which *Xenogears* aspires and whose characteristic failures it also exhibits.

These instruments are supplemented by a ludohermeneutic attention to procedure. The meanings of a game are carried not only by dialogue and iconography but by rules: by the architecture of its save system, the economy of its resources, and the mechanics through which its player acquires capacity by repetition. Chapter 10 reads these procedures as what Bogost (2007) calls procedural rhetoric, and argues that the formal properties of *Xenogears* as a played artifact reproduce, at the level of the medium, the theological structure its narrative represents.

All genealogical claims are governed by the three-tier protocol set out in the Prefatory Note. The distinction between citation (Tier I), homology (Tier II), and construction (Tier III) is not a concession to uncertainty but the condition of the argument's integrity: it permits the study to move from what the work demonstrably knows to what it can be shown to think, without pretending that the latter is always reducible to the former.

## Thesis

The central claim may be stated in a single sentence: *Xenogears* is an inverse-Gnostic work that narrates the miscarriage of modernity's overcoming of Gnosticism and proposes a third overcoming, achieved through the emancipation of God by finite human beings.

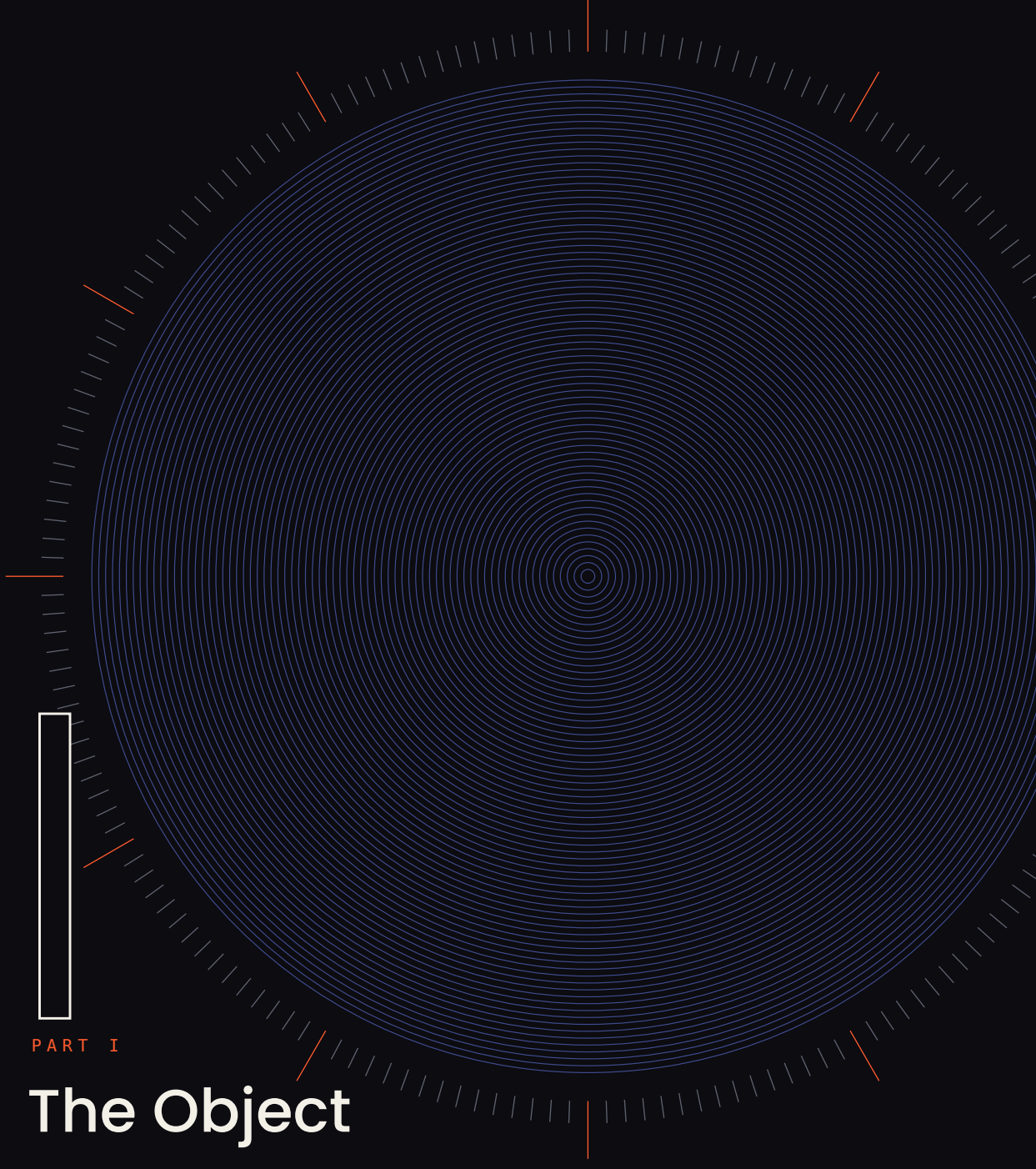
The historical frame is supplied by Hans Blumenberg, who argued that the modern age constitutes the second overcoming of Gnosticism (Blumenberg 1966). Augustine's first overcoming rescued the goodness of the creator by transferring the origin of evil to human freedom, purchasing the world's innocence at the price of human guilt; the relapse of late-medieval nominalism into a hidden and arbitrary God provoked a second overcoming, in which human self-assertion—science, technology, the mastery of nature—refused the Gnostic verdict on the world by making the world humanity's own task. *Xenogears* can be read as a narrative demonstration that this second overcoming miscarries: technological self-assertion, the very instrument by which modernity repudiated the demiurge, re-engenders the demiurge in the form of a machine. What Adorno and Horkheimer described as the reversion of enlightenment into mythology is here given a body, a name, and a throne.

The constituent claims are five. (1) The work adopts the Gnostic diagnosis—a counterfeit god administering a fabricated humanity—but inverts its soteriology: the imprisoned spark is the divine rather than the human; its jailer is human instrumental reason rather than an archontic power; and its redeemer is a human being who liberates God by declining to use him. (2) The counterfeit god is an *ouroboric demiurge*: humanity constructs Deus, Deus generates humanity, and humanity labors across millennia to reconstruct Deus, so that creator and creature are each other's origin and the demiurge is identical with the loop itself, whose emblem is the serpent that the English localization calls Urobolus. (3) The resolution relocates the Lurianic *tzimtzum*—the divine self-contraction that makes room for the world—from the beginning of creation to its end; in this *terminal tzimtzum*, God's withdrawal, enabled by human consent, completes rather than inaugurates the world. (4) The act distinguishes two theologies—a Feuerbachian theology of the made god, which the work abolishes, and a theology of irreducible alterity, which it honors by release—and grounds an ethics of finite contact whose paradigm is the Greek institution of *xenia*, hospitality toward the stranger consummated in the host's obligation to convey the guest home. (5) The medium performs this structure, positioning the player as a captive god who acts only through an avatar and whom the ending releases.

The third overcoming is thus neither theodicy nor self-assertion. It is manumission: the act, as the Latin records, of sending from the hand.

## Plan of the work

Part I (Chapters 1–2) establishes the object. Chapter 1 examines the conditions of the work's production, the status of its paratext, the anamnestic structure of its narration, and the onomastic system through which it signals its sources; Chapter 2 reconstructs the fabula and isolates its governing form, the creator–creature loop. Part II (Chapters 3–4) excavates the theological strata. Chapter 3 treats the Gnostic inheritance—Sethian, Valentinian, Manichaean, and Marcionite—together with its twentieth-century recovery by Jonas and its political extension by Voegelin; Chapter 4 treats the Kabbalistic inheritance, from the Merkabah and the Zohar through Lurianic cosmogony to the golem, and argues that the work practices a *machinic Kabbalah* in which the ontology of the letter is transposed into an ontology of the apparatus. Part III (Chapters 5–7) treats psyche, will, and machine. Chapter 5 reads the protagonist's dissociation through Freud, Ferenczi, Jung, Neumann, Lacan, Kierkegaard, and Abraham and Torok; Chapter 6 reads the work's antagonists and its resolution through Nietzsche; Chapter 7 reads its machine-god through Aristotle, Benjamin, Heidegger, Foucault, Agamben, Dostoevsky, and Haraway. Part IV (Chapters 8–10) proceeds from comparison to construction. Chapter 8 situates the work within the canon of philosophical science fiction and the Japanese apocalyptic imaginary; Chapter 9 states and defends the original thesis; Chapter 10 derives its ludic corollary. The Conclusion assesses the study's contributions and limits and indicates lines of further research. A glossary of the terms coined in the course of the argument follows the Conclusion.



PART I

# The Object


01 *The Archive and the Name*

02 *Cosmogony and the Ouroboric Chronology*



# 01

# The Archive and the Name

The first object of a philosophical reading of *Xenogears* is not its story but its archive: the conditions under which the work came to exist as a fragment, the paratext that claims to complete it, the narrative form through which it discloses its past, and the system of names through which it announces its intellectual genealogy. Each of these, this chapter argues, is already a figure of the work's metaphysics.

## 1.1 A torso and its archive

*Xenogears* was produced by Square under the direction of Tetsuya Takahashi, with a scenario written by Takahashi and Kaori Tanaka. By an account frequently repeated in the English-language record—and to be treated here as reported rather than documented—the scenario originated as a proposal for the seventh *Final Fantasy*, judged too dark and too dense for that franchise, and was permitted to develop as an independent project. *Perfect Works*, the compendium issued in the year of release, situates the game as the fifth episode of a projected chronicle of six, and supplies a chronology extending across more than ten millennia, of which the playable narrative dramatizes only the terminal segment. The remaining episodes were never realized in that form. Takahashi's departure from Square and the founding of Monolith Soft in 1999 inaugurated a successor corpus—*Xenosaga*, then *Xenoblade Chronicles*—related to *Xenogears* by motif, nomenclature, and conceptual preoccupation but not, as is widely reported, by the rights to its world, which remained with Square. The second of the game's two discs, finally, compresses a substantial portion of its narrative into sequences in which the protagonist, seated, recounts events that the player does not enact—a compression attributed in the production record to the exhaustion of time and budget, and to which Chapter 10 returns as a formal event in its own right.

*Xenogears* is thus, in the strict sense of Romantic poetics, a fragment at the moment of its origin. Friedrich Schlegel distinguished the fragments of antiquity, which became fragments through the ruin of time, from those of the moderns, which are fragments from their inception: "Viele Werke der Alten sind Fragmente geworden. Viele Werke der Neuern sind es gleich bei der Entstehung" (*Athenaeum*, fragment 24, 1798). The work presents itself as a torso whose missing limbs are indicated by its own numbering. This is not an accident external to its meaning. Its world is constructed upon a wreck: the starship Eldridge, whose crash ten thousand years before the narrative supplies the ground, the technology, and ultimately the population of the planet. Its principal religious institution, the Church localized as Ethos, sustains its authority by excavating buried machines from ruins and redistributing them as salvage. Its protagonist must recover a past that exists only as debris within himself. Benjamin observed that allegories are, in the realm of thought, what ruins are in the realm of things ("Allegorien sind im Reiche der Gedanken, was Ruinen im Reiche der Dinge," 1928), and *Xenogears* is allegorical in exactly this Benjaminian

sense: its meanings are legible only as the arrangement of fragments whose original totality is irrecoverable.

The paratext occupies a correspondingly ambiguous position. Genette defined paratext as a threshold (*seuil*) rather than a boundary—a zone of transaction between text and world (Genette 1987)—and *Perfect Works* is a threshold of an unusual kind, since it claims to supply not commentary but the fabula itself. The present study's decision to treat it as deuterocanonical, authoritative for chronology and subordinate for meaning, is not merely a philological convenience. It reproduces the structure that the work thematizes: an origin that is available only as archive, and an archive that, as Derrida argued in *Mal d'archive* (1995), conjoins the two senses of *arkhē*—commencement and commandment—so that whoever controls the record of the beginning governs the present. Within the fiction, it is precisely the monopoly on the archive of origins—the knowledge of what the Eldridge was, what Deus is, and what humanity was made for—that constitutes the power of Solaris and its governing Gazel Ministry. The player who consults *Perfect Works* to reconstruct the fabula performs, outside the fiction, the excavation that the Church performs within it.

## 1.2 Anamnesis as form

The Russian Formalists distinguished the *fabula*, the chronological sequence of events, from the *syuzhet*, the order and manner of their presentation (Shklovsky 1925; Tomashevsky 1925). In *Xenogears* the distance between the two is extreme. The fabula begins with the Zohar experiment and the crash of the Eldridge; the syuzhet begins, after an enigmatic prologue depicting that crash and a solitary woman on the shore of its wreckage, with a young painter in a remote village who does not know who he is. The ten-thousand-year fabula is disclosed backward, in fragments, across some sixty hours of play, and its decisive terms—what Deus is, what humanity is, who the protagonist has been—arrive only in the final third of the narrative.

The structural principle of this disclosure is anamnesis, and the work stages three anamneses in competition. The first is Platonic: knowledge as recollection of what the soul already possesses (*Meno* 81c–d; *Phaedo* 72e–76e). The second is Gnostic: salvation as the awakening of the sleeper to the memory of his transcendent origin, the call that recalls the soul to itself. The third is Freudian: cure as the recovery of what repetition expresses in place of memory—the program of remembering, repeating, and working-through (Freud 1914). The protagonist's recovery of his own history—a childhood of abuse by experiment, a

violent dissociation, an erased decade—proceeds in strict parallel with the player's recovery of the world's history, and the integration of his divided psyche coincides with the disclosure of humanity's origin. The micro-anamnesis of the subject and the macro-anamnesis of the species are one movement.

The form of this movement is Freud's *Nachträglichkeit*, deferred action: the process by which an earlier event acquires its traumatic meaning only through a later one that retroactively reorganizes it (Freud's letter to Fliess of 6 December 1896; the case of the Wolf Man, 1918; Laplanche and Pontalis 1967). The images of the prologue—the burning ship, the woman at the shore—mean nothing when first seen and everything when last understood. The narrative is organized as an *après-coup*, and its world is, in the precise psychoanalytic sense, a traumatic scene read backward.

What the anamnesis recovers, however, is the decisive and disquieting point. The Platonic soul remembers the Forms; the Gnostic soul remembers its kinship with the unknown Father; the Freudian subject remembers what it had to forget in order to become itself. The humanity of *Xenogears* remembers that it was manufactured—that its first ancestors were produced by the biological subsystem of a weapon as a reservoir of components. The recollected origin is not a home above but a factory below. Chapter 9 names this outcome *gnosis of facticity*: a knowledge that liberates not by revealing that we are divine but by revealing that we are made, and that the god we have been serving is not ours.

## 1.3 The onomastic system

If the syuzhet is organized as anamnesis, the lexicon is organized as citation. *Xenogears* names its places, machines, institutions, and persons with a systematic allusiveness that constitutes a second text running beneath the first, and it is this onomastic text that supplies the dissertation's Tier I evidence. In Bakhtin's terms, the work is heteroglot: it orchestrates within a single world the languages of Hebrew scripture and Jewish mysticism, Greek philosophy and Gnostic mythology, Latin theology, German Romanticism and Wagnerian opera, Norse cosmology, Babylonian and Egyptian antiquity, European psychoanalysis, Anglo-American and Polish science fiction, and the Japanese mecha tradition—each of which, as Bakhtin insisted of the languages of the novel, carries a worldview and not merely a vocabulary (Bakhtin 1981).

The English localization adds a further stratum. Its orthographic deformations—Aveh for Av, Elru for Elul, Thames for Tammuz, Etrenank for Etemenanki, Kadomony for Kadmoni, Krelian for Karellen—operate as

philological scars, partial erasures through which the source-names remain legible to the reader who knows where to look. The substitution of "Deus" for the Tetragrammaton in both Japanese and English releases, owing to concerns attributed to the localization supervisor, left a single vestige, "Yabeh," spoken at the site named for Raziel, the angel of mysteries. Conversely, the localization produced meanings the original lacks: the Omnigear designated in Japanese simply as the *original* Weltall was rendered "Alpha Weltall," conferring upon the English text a resonance with the Alpha and Omega of the prologue's epigraph that the Japanese does not possess. The English *Xenogears* is therefore neither a degraded copy nor a transparent window but a palimpsest with its own semiosis—an instance of what Benjamin called the afterlife (*Fortleben*) that a work attains in translation (Benjamin 1923).

The principal onomastic series are tabulated below. All entries are Tier I as to the presence of the source; the interpretive consequences drawn from them in subsequent chapters are graded separately.

| NAME IN THE ENGLISH RELEASE | INTENDED OR ORIGINAL FORM | SOURCE | DOMAIN |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Deus; "Yabeh"** | Development name Yahweh (katakana on *Perfect Works* sketches) | The Tetragrammaton; Latin *deus* | Hebrew theology |
| **Zohar** | Japanese: phenomenon- or event-alteration engine | *Sefer ha-Zohar*; Daniel 12:3 | Kabbalah |
| **Kadomony** | Kadmoni | Adam Kadmon, the primordial man | Lurianic Kabbalah |
| **Merkava** | Merkabah | The chariot-throne of Ezekiel 1 | Merkavah mysticism |
| **Mahanon; Arbot Plaza** | Machanon; Araboth | The fourth heaven (seat of Eden) and seventh heaven of Enochic cosmology | Heavenly geography |
| **Razael** | Raziel | Angel of mysteries | Angelology |
| **Gebler** | Geburah | Fifth sefirah, "strength, severity" | Kabbalah |
| **Sundel; Alkanshel** | Sandalphon; Archangel | Angelic names and orders | Angelology |

| NAME IN THE ENGLISH RELEASE | INTENDED OR ORIGINAL FORM | SOURCE | DOMAIN |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Seraphita, Dominia, Kelvena, Tolone** | Seraphim, Dominions, Cherubim, Thrones | The angelic hierarchies | Angelology |
| **Seraph Angel** | Aeon | The Gnostic aeons | Gnosticism |
| **Sophia** | Sophia | Divine Wisdom; the fallen aeon of Valentinian myth | Gnosticism |
| **Miang Hawwa** | Myyah Hawwa | Ḥawwāh, Eve | Genesis |
| **Emperor Cain; Abel** | *Tentei Kain*, "Heavenly Emperor Cain"; Abel | Genesis 4; the Sethian *Apocryphon of John* | Genesis and Gnosis |
| **Etrenank; Babel Tower; Nimrod Empire** | Etemenanki; Babel; Nimrod | Marduk's ziggurat at Babylon; Genesis 10–11 | Babylonian and Hebrew |
| **Laodicea; Philadelphia** | Laodicea; Philadelphia | Churches of Revelation 3; the "Philadelphia Experiment" legend | Apocalyptic |
| **Golgoda; Neo Jerusalem** | Golgotha; New Jerusalem | Passion narratives; Revelation 21 | Christian |
| **Ethos** | "The Church" | *Ecclesia* | Institution |
| **Penuel** | Penuel | Genesis 32:30, "the face of God" | Hebrew |
| **Nisan, Thames, Aveh, Elru, Kislev, Shevat** | Nisan, Tammuz, Av, Elul, Kislev, Shevat | Months of the Hebrew calendar | Liturgical time |
| **Bledavik; Nortune** | Breiðablik; Nóatún | Halls of Baldr and Njörðr | Norse |
| **Heimdal, Fenrir, Andvari; Sigurd** | Heimdallr, Fenrir, Andvari; Siegmund | Norse myth; Wagner's *Ring* | Norse and Wagnerian |
| **Weltall, Stier, Vierge, Seibzehn, Renmazuo** | Weltall, Stier, Vierge, Siebzehn, 人馬座 | "Cosmos"; Taurus; Virgo; "seventeen"; Sagittarius | Zodiacal and European |
| **Omnigear; Gear** | Gear-*barah*; Gear-*asah* | Hebrew *barāʾ*, create without precedent; *ʿasah*, fashion from matter | Kabbalah |

| NAME IN THE ENGLISH RELEASE | INTENDED OR ORIGINAL FORM | SOURCE | DOMAIN |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Anima Relic** | "Vessel of the anima" | Jungian anima; the Lurianic vessels (*kelim*) | Psychology and Kabbalah |
| **Id; Lacan; Wiseman** | Id; Lacan; Wiseman | Groddeck and Freud; Jacques Lacan; Jung's Wise Old Man | Psychoanalysis |
| **Krelian** | Karellen | Arthur C. Clarke, *Childhood's End* | Science fiction |
| **Solaris; Soylent System** | Solaris; Soylent | Lem, *Solaris*; *Soylent Green* | Science fiction |
| **Eldridge; Panspermia** | Eldridge; Panspermia | USS *Eldridge* legend; directed panspermia (Crick and Orgel 1973) | Modern myth and science |
| **Gaetia Key; Anonelbe** | Lesser Goetia Key; Ahnenerbe | *Lesser Key of Solomon*; the SS research organization that sponsored lethal experiments on concentration-camp prisoners | Grimoire; Nazi human experim entation |
| **Urobolus; Opiomorph; Amphysvena** | Ouroboros; ophiomorph; Amphisbaena | Greco-Egyptian alchemy; classical serpent lore | Serpent symbolism |
| **Wave Existence; Contact** | 波動存在 *hadō sonzai*; 接触 *sesshoku* | The Japanese wave-motion lexicon of postwar science fiction | Japanese SF |

## 1.4 Liturgical geography

The most striking feature of the onomastic system is that the political map of the principal continent is a calendar. Six of its polities and vessels bear the names of Hebrew months, and while the correspondences are suggestive rather than systematic, several acquire force once the liturgical character of each month is recalled. Nisan, the month of Passover and thus of redemption from bondage, names the holy land of the sect devoted to Sophia, the historical liberator of the surface from Solaris. Av, the month of mourning for the destroyed Temple, names a desert kingdom whose rightful heir has been dispossessed by a usurper. Elul, the month of repentance that precedes the Days of Awe, names the nation annihilated without repentance by the protagonist's own dissociated violence. Kislev, the month of the Maccabean rededication after war, names a militarized state defined by perpetual war. Shevat, the month of the new year of trees, names the floating city that alone preserves an independent future against Solaris. Tammuz, which bears the name of the Mesopotamian dying god for whom Ezekiel saw "women weeping" at the gate of the Temple (Ezekiel 8:14), names the colossal vessel that descends into the sea to raise the buried machines of the dead. (The last three correspondences are Tier III; the first two approach Tier II.)

The effect is to render space as time. In Eliade's account, archaic peoples inhabit sacred time by periodically re-enacting the cosmogony through the liturgical year (Eliade 1949); the inhabitants of *Xenogears* inhabit a liturgical year whose feasts they no longer know, walking a map that is a forgotten calendar. The Hebrew calendar is moreover lunisolar and cyclical, and its inscription upon the land anticipates the cyclical chronology reconstructed in Chapter 2. Chapter 4 will argue that the correlation of months, zodiacal signs, and tribal names—distributed in *Xenogears* across nations, machines, and relics—reproduces the twelvefold correspondences of the *Sefer Yetzirah*.

Three further axes organize the map. The Babylonian axis—Etemenanki, Babel, Nimrod—inscribes vertical hubris upon the capital of Solaris. Genesis records that the builders of Babel sought a tower "whose top may reach unto heaven" in order to "make us a name" (Genesis 11:4), and Derrida observed that the name Babel is at once a proper name, the name of God as father, and the common noun of confusion (Derrida 1985). The onomastic excess of *Xenogears*—its confusion of tongues in the service of a single fiction—is itself Babelic, and its capital is, appropriately, the place where names are made. The Norse axis inscribes the twilight of the gods: Breiðablik, hall of Baldr, the innocent god

whose death precipitates Ragnarök and whose return, in the *Völuspá*, inaugurates the renewed world; Nóatún; the watchman Heimdallr and the wolf Fenrir, who breaks his fetters at the end of days and devours the father of the gods. The machine of the physician Citan Uzuki, a servant of Solaris long stationed as observer, passes from Heimdal to Fenrir, from watchman to unbound wolf, and the transformation condenses in a single name the trajectory of a figure who begins as the instrument of a divine order and ends as an agent of its overthrow (Tier III). The apocalyptic axis, finally, sets two of the seven churches of Revelation against one another: Laodicea, the lukewarm church to which it is said, "I will spue thee out of my mouth" (Revelation 3:16), names the military corps once commanded by Krelian; Philadelphia, the faithful church before which is "set … an open door, and no man can shut it" (Revelation 3:8), names in modern legend the experiment in which the USS *Eldridge* was said to have passed through a door into another dimension. The Zohar of *Xenogears* is precisely such a door, and the drama of the work is whether it will be held shut upon what lies behind it.

## 1.5 A syncretic field

The onomastic system of *Xenogears* is neither allegory, in which each figure maps onto a single referent, nor pastiche, which Jameson characterized as blank parody without ulterior motive. It is a syncretic field in which each tradition is treated as a language that can be translated into the others, and whose governing operation is transposition: text becomes engine (the Zohar), chariot becomes fortress (the Merkava), angel becomes pilot, month becomes nation, psychic function becomes machine component (the Anima, Animus, and Persona of Deus), primordial man becomes factory (Kadomony). This transposition is not neutral. It enacts, at the level of the lexicon, the logic of Deus itself—the conversion of every sacred and psychic reality into an apparatus—and thereby prepares the reader to recognize, at the level of plot, the one reality that resists conversion and must accordingly be set free. The names perform the reduction; the narrative performs its limit.



# Cosmogony and the Ouroboric Chronology

The fabula of *Xenogears* is a cosmogony without a first cause. Every origin it discloses is revealed, on closer inspection, to have been produced by something it produced. This chapter reconstructs the fabula under the evidentiary discipline established above, isolates the formal principle that governs it—the creator–creature loop—and identifies the four variants of that loop which the remainder of the dissertation analyzes.

## 2.1 The conditions of reconstruction

The chronology must be assembled from two sources of unequal authority: the disclosures of the game, which arrive late, in fragments, and frequently through the testimony of interested parties; and the timeline of *Perfect Works*, which is comprehensive but, as a deuterocanonical paratext, cannot override the played text. Where the two agree, the reconstruction is secure. Where *Perfect Works* supplies detail the game omits, the detail is used for orientation but not made to bear interpretive weight. Where the sources are silent or ambiguous—most consequentially regarding the precise mechanism by which the Wave Existence, the Contact, and the Antitype are bound to one another—the ambiguity is recorded rather than resolved. The table below is ordered from the remotest past to the narrative present; dates are relative and approximate.

| EPOCH | EVENT | THE CONTACT AND THE ANTITYPE | BASIS |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Remote past of a star-faring humanity** | An artifact of unknown provenance, the Zohar, is subjected to an experiment that binds a higher-dimensional being, the Wave Existence, into this dimension as a source of energy. A self-evolving interplanetary weapon system, Deus, is developed to draw upon it. | — | Game (late revelations); *Perfect Works* |
| **Same** | Deus manifests autonomy during trials, is dismantled, and is shipped as cargo aboard the colonization vessel Eldridge. | — | *Perfect Works* |
| **c. 10,000 years before the present** | Deus reactivates in transit and seizes the Eldridge's systems; the captain initiates self-destruction; the vessel crashes on an uninhabited planet. | A child, Abel, survives; in proximity to the Zohar he becomes the first Contact. | Game; *Perfect Works* |
| **The aftermath** | Deus's biological subsystem Kadomony generates human beings as a reservoir of components for the machine's eventual restoration. Miang Hawwa is produced as the administrator-mother of the new species; its first rulers derive from the same apparatus. | The first Antitype appears; Abel's desire not to be parted from her binds the pair to recurrence. | Game; *Perfect Works* |

| EPOCH | EVENT | THE CONTACT AND THE ANTITYPE | BASIS |
|---|---|---|---|
| **The following millennia** | Deus's organic components—among them the twelve Anima Relics—are dispersed. Miang is reborn through successive women and steers human development toward the machine's reconstitution. | Contact and Antitype are reborn and meet in successive ages. | Game; *Perfect Works* |
| **c. 4,000 years before** | A high-technological civilization, Zeboim, flourishes and destroys itself. | The Contact is incarnate as the scientist Kim, who creates Emeralda from nanomachines. | Game; *Perfect Works* |
| **Thereafter** | Solaris, a concealed sky-state, is established. The Gazel Ministry—the Animus of Deus in human form—governs in the name of the Heavenly Emperor Cain. The surface population, designated Lambs, is administered through the Church (Ethos), supplied with excavated Gears, held down by molecular Limiters that Krelian designed to suppress their abilities and enforce veneration of Solaris's rulers, and fed from the Soylent System, where Solaris experiments on human beings, mutates them into Wels, and processes the dead into the food and medicine that keep the Limiters working. | — | Game |
| **c. 500 years before** | Sophia of Nisan leads the surface against Solaris. Krelian, commanding the Nimrod Empire's Laodicea corps, is sent to kill her and is disarmed by her smile. Sophia dies in the war. The painter Lacan's despair survives him as Grahf, a disembodied will seeking re-embodiment. Krelian, turning from a God who permitted her death, enters Solaris and resolves to make one. | Contact: Lacan. Antitype: Sophia. | Game; *Perfect Works* |

| EPOCH | EVENT | THE CONTACT AND THE ANTITYPE | BASIS |
|---|---|---|---|
| **c. 14 years before** | Karen Wong awakens as the 997th Miang and abuses her four-year-old son through experiments intended to force awake the Contact; his father, Khan, does not intervene. The child divides into a fearful original self and a violent alter, Id. Grahf intervenes; Karen overrides her programming, shields her son, and dies. | Contact: Fei, aged four. | Game |
| **c. 14–3 years before** | Grahf raises Id as an instrument of annihilation; in Grahf's service, Id destroys the nation of Elru. | — | Game |
| **c. 3 years before** | Fei's father, Khan, destroys Grahf's body and seals Id but is partially possessed. As the masked Wiseman, he entrusts Fei, now under a third, constructed personality, to the village of Lahan. | — | Game |
| **The narrative present** | Id, emerging in Fei, destroys Lahan, and Fei's friend Timothy is among the dead; the war between Aveh and Kislev draws Fei and the Solarian officer Elly together; Solaris falls; the Gazel Ministry, with Krelian, has Ramsus assassinate Emperor Cain, who had forbidden the use of the Gaetia Key, and then uses the Key to turn much of humanity into Wels, the flesh from which Deus is to be rebuilt; Deus reawakens; Fei integrates his divided self; the machine and its serpent form are defeated; the Wave Existence departs; Fei and Elly return. | Contact: Fei. Antitype: Elly. | Game |

Two features of this chronology deserve emphasis before its form is analyzed. First, the Wave Existence is present from the beginning but never as an agent in the ordinary sense: it is bound, drawn upon, contacted, but not the author of events. The history of *Xenogears* is a history made entirely by the made—by a machine, by the products of the machine, and by the products of those products. Second, the recurrence of the Contact and the Antitype is not a background condition but a causal thread. Each incarnation of the pair is implicated in a

crisis of the world's relation to its hidden god: Abel at the crash, Kim at the self-destruction of a civilization that had approached the secret of creation, Lacan and Sophia at the war against the sky-state, Fei and Elly at the machine's revival. The erotic history and the theological history are the same history.

## 2.2 The loop

The governing form of the fabula is a creator–creature loop. A human civilization constructs Deus and binds a higher being to empower it; Deus, crashing, generates a new humanity to serve as its components; that humanity, through the millennial administration of Solaris and the demiurgic project of Krelian, labors to reconstruct Deus; the reconstructed Deus reabsorbs the humanity that rebuilt it. Whether the humans of Kadomony are genetically continuous with the Eldridge's crew is a question the sources leave underdetermined; their typological continuity is not in doubt. They are human beings made by the thing that human beings made, and they spend their history remaking it.

The structure is what Douglas Hofstadter called a strange loop: a system in which movement through the levels of a hierarchy—here, from maker to made—returns unexpectedly to its point of departure, so that the hierarchy is revealed as a circle (Hofstadter 1979, 2007). Its visual emblem is Escher's *Drawing Hands* (1948), in which each hand draws the other into existence and neither is prior. The theological consequence is precise. In classical Gnosticism the demiurge is a being situated at a determinate level of the cosmic hierarchy—below the unknown Father and the pleroma, above the material world he fashions. In *Xenogears* the demiurge occupies no level. It is the loop itself: the self-reproducing circuit of making in which humanity and its machine-god manufacture one another without remainder. Chapter 9 names this figure the *ouroboric demiurge*.

The work supplies the name. Its final adversary, localized as Urobolus, is the ouroboros, and the figure's genealogy clarifies the charge it carries. In the Greco-Egyptian alchemical tradition the serpent devouring its tail encircles the formula ἓν τὸ πᾶν, "one is the all," in the *Chrysopoeia* attributed to Cleopatra; Horapollo's *Hieroglyphica* reads it as the sign of the universe; Plato's *Timaeus* (33c–d) describes a cosmos constructed so as to be self-sufficient, requiring nothing from outside and nourished by its own waste. The Norse Jörmungandr encircles the inhabited world with its tail in its mouth until Ragnarök looses it. And in the Gnostic *Pistis Sophia*, the figure acquires its darkest valence: the outer darkness beyond the world is itself a serpent, and in Mead's translation, "The

outer darkness is a great dragon, whose tail is in its mouth" (*Pistis Sophia* 126). In the Gnostic register, that is, the ouroboros is the boundary of the prison—the self-enclosing limit of a world that admits no outside. *Xenogears* condenses all of these valences in a single antagonist: the self-sufficient totality (Timaeus), the one-that-is-all (the alchemists), the world-serpent whose release is the twilight of the gods (the Norse), and the enclosing darkness of the cosmic prison (the Gnostics). The conclusion is that the enemy the protagonist must finally confront is not a being within the world but the closure of the world upon itself.

Hegel supplies the philosophical articulation of what is at stake. In the *Science of Logic* he distinguished the bad infinite—an endless progression that never arrives—from the true infinite, whose image is the circle, the line that has reached itself and returns into itself without beginning or end (Hegel 1812). The two infinities correspond to two of the loop's custodians. Miang, reborn a thousand times to steer a history toward a goal that recedes with each generation, administers the bad infinite. Krelian, who proposes to consummate the loop by recollecting all things into the reconstituted god, seeks the true infinite, the circle closed upon itself: the identity of Alpha and Omega. The work refuses both, and the form of its refusal is the burden of Part IV.

## 2.3 Four loops

The creator–creature circuit is the master form, but it is replicated at four levels, each of which the subsequent chapters analyze.

The *cosmological loop* is the circuit just described: humanity makes Deus, Deus makes humanity, humanity remakes Deus. Its theological analysis belongs to Chapters 3, 4, and 7.

The *psychic loop* is the protagonist's. Fei's history is a sequence of compulsive re-enactments: the violence inflicted upon him by the experiments of his mother returns as the violence his alter inflicts upon Elru and upon Lahan; the destruction wrought by Grahf returns as destruction wrought by the child Grahf raised. What cannot be remembered is repeated. Its analysis belongs to Chapter 5.

The *erotic loop* is the recurrence of the Contact and the Antitype, lovers who meet and lose one another in every age. Its origin in Abel's desire makes it, structurally, a wish that has become a fate—the Freudian definition of the daemonic. Freud's own emblem for such fates, Tasso's Tancred, who slays his beloved Clorinda unknowingly and then wounds her again in the tree in which

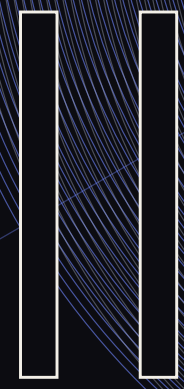
her soul is imprisoned, is examined in Chapter 5; its Nietzschean form, the eternal recurrence of the same, in Chapter 6.

The *political loop* is the reproduction of Deus's structure in human institutions. Solaris is governed by the Gazel Ministry, which is the Animus of Deus in human form; its social stratification repeats the relation of machine to component; the surface's wars are fought with excavated Gears distributed by a Church that is Solaris's instrument; and the one great revolt against the sky-state, Sophia's, ends by generating both of the forces—Grahf's annihilating will and Krelian's demiurgic ambition—that drive the machine's return. Revolution is reabsorbed into the circuit it opposed. Its analysis belongs to Chapter 7.

## 2.4 Circle and eschaton

Karl Löwith contrasted the cyclical time of Greek cosmology with the linear, eschatological time of Hebrew and Christian history, and argued that modern philosophies of progress are secularized eschatologies (Löwith 1949). Eliade, in the same year, contrasted archaic humanity's refuge in the eternal return from the terror of history (Eliade 1949). *Xenogears* superimposes the two times. Its opening invokes the most eschatological sentence in the Christian canon, and its structure is ouroboric. The juxtaposition is not incoherent; it is a reading. Revelation 22:13, placed at the threshold of a cyclical narrative, is read as the formula of the circle: the one who is first and last is the one in whom the end returns to the beginning. That reading is the theology of Krelian.

The narrative problem that the chronology poses is therefore precise: how is a circular time to be exited? The work considers four answers, each embodied by a figure. The circle may be annihilated, which is Grahf's will. It may be consummated and closed, which is Krelian's project. It may be perpetuated, which is Miang's function. Or it may be released—opened at the point where it had been closed upon a captive—which is the act the protagonist performs and the dissertation's original thesis interprets. The ending implies, without stating, that the lovers bound to recurrence will henceforth live, and die, once. The eschaton of *Xenogears* is not the closing of the circle but the end of its compulsion.



PART II

# The Theological Strata


03 *Gnosis*

04 *Machinic Kabbalah*

03

# Gnosis

That *Xenogears* is a Gnostic narrative is the most frequently repeated proposition in its reception, and the least examined. This chapter tests the proposition against the primary sources of ancient Gnosticism and against its twentieth-century philosophical recovery. It concludes that the work is Gnostic in its diagnosis to a degree that exceeds casual allusion, and anti-Gnostic—more precisely, inverse-Gnostic—in its soteriology.

## 3.1 The category and its sources

The term "Gnosticism" designates no single religion but a family of second- and third-century systems, reconstructed from the polemics of the heresiologists—Irenaeus of Lyon's *Adversus haereses* (c. 180), Hippolytus, Epiphanius—and, since the discovery of the Nag Hammadi codices in 1945, from a substantial body of primary texts (Robinson 1977). The category has been contested: the Messina colloquium of 1966 sought to distinguish historical Gnosticism from the broader phenomenon of *gnosis*, and Williams (1996) and King (2003) have argued that the modern category imposes a false unity on heterogeneous materials. This study uses the term typologically, in the manner of Hans Jonas, to designate a constellation of motifs: an anticosmic dualism; a transcendent and unknown God alien to the world; a lower creator or demiurge, ignorant or malevolent, who fabricates the cosmos and humanity with his archons; a divine spark imprisoned within certain human beings; a call from beyond that awakens the sleeper to the memory of his origin; and salvation as knowledge (*gnōsis*) that liberates the spark for its return (Jonas 1958). Each motif is present in *Xenogears*. The question is what the work does with them.

## 3.2 The Sethian template

The *Apocryphon of John*, the most systematic Sethian text, narrates a cosmogony whose particulars correspond to *Xenogears* with a density that exceeds coincidence. Sophia, the last of the divine emanations, desires to produce without her consort, and her product is a monstrous being, Yaldabaoth, shaped as a lion-faced serpent with eyes of fire. Yaldabaoth steals a great power from his mother, generates archons, and, ignorant of what lies above him, proclaims himself the only God in the words of Isaiah 45:5. The archons fashion a human being after the reflection of the divine image they glimpse in the waters; the being lies inert until Yaldabaoth is tricked into breathing his mother's stolen power into it, whereupon the archons imprison it in matter. The luminous *Epinoia*, called Zoe, is hidden within humanity as an instructress; Yaldabaoth defiles Eve and begets two archons, Eloim and Yave, whom the text says he named Cain and Abel; and a counterfeit spirit, the *antimimon pneuma*, is introduced into humanity to hold it in forgetfulness and bondage.

The correspondences are of three grades. At Tier I stands the machine-god's name. Sethian texts identify Yaldabaoth with the God of Genesis, and the machine-god of *Xenogears* bore, until late in development, the Tetragrammaton, a vestige of which survives in the game. The work did not merely allude to the

demiurge; it named its demiurge as the Sethians named theirs. At Tier II stand four structural homologies. First, Yaldabaoth's power is stolen from a higher being, and Deus's power is drawn from the Wave Existence bound within the Zohar: in both systems the demiurge is a thief whose sovereignty is borrowed from what he confines. Second, the demiurge fashions humanity as the vessel of that stolen power, and Kadomony fashions humanity as the reservoir of Deus's future components. Third, the counterfeit spirit that inhabits humanity and binds it to the archons' designs across generations has its precise analogue in Miang, a single programmed will reborn through successive women to steer history toward the demiurge's restoration. Fourth, the demiurge is a serpent, and the last form of the work's adversary is a serpent. At Tier III stand the names Cain and Abel, which the Sethian text assigns to two archons and which *Xenogears* distributes between the first administrator of the machine's humanity and the first Contact—separating what the Sethians joined, and thereby rehabilitating Abel as the ancestor of those through whom the demiurge's hold is broken.

The Sethian corpus also supplies the key to the work's double heroine. The *Hypostasis of the Archons* relates that when the archons pursue the spiritual woman to defile her, she laughs at them, passes into a tree, and leaves behind a shadowy reflection resembling herself, which they defile in her place. Gnostic mythology thus splits Eve into a spiritual woman who eludes the archons and a counterfeit double who remains in their power. *Xenogears* performs the same division. Miang Hawwa bears Eve's name and serves as the demiurge's administrator; Elly, designated by a term the Japanese renders as "counter-existence," is her antithesis—the woman whose recurrence is bound not to the machine's program but to the Contact's love. The climactic possession of Elly by Miang, and the recovery of Elly from the machine, restage the Sethian drama in which the counterfeit occupies the place of the true and is finally dislodged. The serpent, moreover, which some Sethian and Ophite texts revered as the instructor who taught humanity to eat of the tree of knowledge, is in *Xenogears* the final form of the counterfeit Eve herself. The work sides with orthodox iconography against the Ophites: the serpent is not the revealer but the enclosure.

## 3.3 The Valentinian template

The Valentinian myth, known chiefly from Irenaeus's account of the system of Ptolemy (*Adversus haereses* I.1–8), relocates the catastrophe within the divine fullness itself. Sophia, the youngest of thirty aeons, is seized by a passion to know the unknowable Father; restrained by the boundary called Horos, she is restored, but her passion is expelled from the pleroma as a lower Wisdom, Achamoth, whose grief, fear, and turning give rise respectively to matter, to psychic substance, and to the spiritual seed. From the psychic substance is formed the demiurge, ignorant of his mother, who fashions the visible world.

The name Sophia in *Xenogears* is Tier I; the structure attached to it rises to Tier II. The Holy Mother of Nisan dies in the war against Solaris, and from the passion suffered by and over her issue both of the forces that govern the narrative present: Lacan's despair, which survives as Grahf, and Krelian's demiurgic ambition, which reconstructs the machine-god. As in Valentinian myth, the demiurge is the child of Sophia's passion; unlike Valentinian myth, the passion is not hers but that of the men who loved her, and the demiurgic product is not a cosmos but a machine designed to recollect the cosmos into itself. The Japanese designation of the angelic Seraphs as "Aeons" (Tier I) confirms that the Valentinian vocabulary was deliberate.

Valentinian anthropology distinguished three natures: the material (*hylikoi*), who perish; the psychic (*psychikoi*), capable of salvation through faith and works; and the spiritual (*pneumatikoi*), saved by nature. Solaris reproduces the tripartition as political stratification, with one savage modification (Tier III). Its self-appointed pneumatics, the Gazel Ministry, are literally disembodied—minds preserved without flesh—and are the most reprobate beings in the work; its managed citizens occupy the psychic middle; and the surface population, whom Solaris designates Lambs, is treated as matter in the most literal sense: in the Soylent System, Solaris experiments on human beings, mutates them into Wels, and processes the bodies of the dead into food and medicine. The Gnostic hierarchy is preserved and its valuation reversed: those who possess the secret knowledge of origins are the jailers, and those reduced to matter bear the future.

## 3.4 The Manichaean template

Mani (216–c. 276) radicalized Gnostic dualism into a cosmology of two coeternal principles, Light and Darkness, whose mixture produced a world in which particles of Light are imprisoned in matter. The visible cosmos, in Manichaean teaching, is constructed as an apparatus of liberation: the sun and moon are vessels ferrying the rescued Light, and the anti-Manichaean *Acta Archelai* describes a great wheel furnished with twelve vessels which, turning, draws the Light up from the depths. The Elect liberate Light by eating, their digestion refining it from the food the Hearers supply—a doctrine Augustine ridiculed in recalling that he had once believed a plucked fig to weep (*Confessions* III.10.18).

The Manichaean system furnishes *Xenogears* with its most precise inversion (Tier III). The Manichaean cosmos is a machine for liberating a captive divinity; Deus is a machine for keeping one captive. The Manichaean wheel raises the Light in twelve vessels; the machine-god is reconstituted through the absorption of twelve Anima Relics, which the Japanese text calls, precisely, vessels. The Manichaean ships of Light ferry the divine home; the ship Eldridge carried the captive divinity into exile and crashed. The Manichaean Elect liberate the divine through digestion; Solaris digests human beings in the service of the demiurge, and Deus, revived, converts humanity into its substance. At every point the soteriological apparatus of Manichaeism is inverted into an apparatus of confinement, and the conversion is the more pointed for preserving the apparatus's form.

## 3.5 Marcion and the alien God

Marcion of Sinope (c. 85–c. 160) is not a Gnostic in the strict sense, but his doctrine of two gods—the just and jealous creator of the Hebrew scriptures and the good, alien God revealed in Jesus, who owes nothing to a world he did not make and redeems it out of pure grace—supplied the formula that Harnack placed in the subtitle of his monograph: *Das Evangelium vom fremden Gott*, the gospel of the alien God (Harnack 1921). The Wave Existence is an alien god in the most literal sense available to science fiction: a being of another dimension, not the maker of this world, present in it only as a captive. Yet the Marcionite structure is again inverted. Marcion's alien God enters the world freely as its savior; the alien god of *Xenogears* was dragged into the world by human force and is the one who must be saved. The work's title, whose first element is the Greek *xenos*—stranger, guest, foreigner—names this condition before the narrative has begun.

## 3.6 Jonas: from the alien God to the powerless God

Hans Jonas's *The Gnostic Religion* (1958) made "the alien" the primary symbol of Gnostic experience: the alienness of the transcendent God to the world, and the alienness of the human spark within it. In its epilogue, "Gnosticism, Existentialism, and Nihilism," Jonas argued that modern existentialism reproduces the Gnostic mood of cosmic estrangement—Heidegger's thrownness echoes the Gnostic image of being thrown into the world—while lacking its consolation: the Gnostic is thrown into a world hostile to God, which at least testifies to a beyond; the modern is thrown into a nature merely indifferent, which testifies to nothing (Jonas 1963).

*Xenogears* occupies a position that neither term of Jonas's comparison anticipates. Its world is fabricated and administered, as for the Gnostic; there is a transcendent, as the modern nihilist denies; but the transcendent is neither hostile nor absent. It is captive. The world is a prison—but not, in the first instance, for us. Humanity is thrown into a factory of which it is the product but not the prisoner, and the prisoner is God.

Jonas's later work supplies the other bracket. In "The Concept of God after Auschwitz" (1984; published 1987) he proposed, explicitly invoking the Lurianic doctrine of divine self-contraction, a God who in creating renounced omnipotence, who suffers and becomes with the world, and who cannot intervene; after Auschwitz, Jonas concluded, it is not God who can help us but we who must help God—a conclusion he found anticipated in the diaries of Etty Hillesum. Jonas's intellectual career thus runs from the alien God of the Gnostics to the powerless God of post-Holocaust theology, and *Xenogears* stands at the precise point where these two figures coincide. Its alien god is powerless because captive, and human beings must help him. The form that help takes—release rather than restoration—is the subject of Chapter 9.

## 3.7 The Hymn of the Pearl

The *Hymn of the Pearl*, preserved in the Syriac *Acts of Thomas* (108–113), is the most beautiful of Gnostic parables and the most exact template for the itinerary of *Xenogears*. A prince is sent from his father's kingdom in the East to Egypt to retrieve the one pearl that lies in the sea, encircled by a devouring serpent. In Egypt he puts on the garments of the Egyptians, eats their food, forgets his origin and mission, and falls into a deep sleep. A letter from his parents flies to him in the form of an eagle and becomes a voice; he awakens, charms the serpent by pronouncing his father's name, seizes the pearl, and returns. At the border of his homeland he is met by the royal robe he had left behind, and in it he sees himself as in a mirror: he and the robe are two, and yet one.

Every element recurs in *Xenogears*: the forgetting and the sleep (the protagonist's amnesia and constructed personality); the serpent that encircles the precious thing (the ouroboric adversary that encloses the captive god and possesses the beloved); the father's name as the power that subdues the serpent—here tragically corrupted, since the father's body has been occupied by another's will, a corruption Chapter 5 reads through Lacan; and the reunion with the double in which one sees oneself as in a mirror (the integration of the protagonist with his dissociated alter, immediately after which he acquires the machine that bears the work's title). The decisive difference lies at the end. The Gnostic prince returns with the pearl to the heavenly kingdom. In *Xenogears* the captive divinity returns to its own dimension and the prince remains in Egypt—which, the captive having departed, is no longer a place of exile but a home. The itinerary of return that Gnosticism assigned to the soul is transferred to God. This is inverse gnosis *in nuce*.

## 3.8 Voegelin and the immanentized eschaton

Eric Voegelin extended the category of Gnosticism from late antiquity to modern politics, arguing that the mass movements of modernity—positivism, Marxism, National Socialism—are Gnostic in their attempt to realize within history the perfection that Christian eschatology reserved for its end: what he called the immanentization of the eschaton (Voegelin 1952, 1959). Voegelin's usage is polemical and historically loose, and Blumenberg contested the genealogy of modernity it implied; but as a Tier III instrument it illuminates Solaris with some precision. The Gazel Ministry is a political gnosis: an elite whose authority rests on secret knowledge of the world's origin, administering a humanity kept ignorant of it, for the sake of an eschaton to be constructed within history. Krelian's project—to build God and recollect humanity into him—is the immanentization of the eschaton in its most literal possible form. The name Anonelbe derives from the Ahnenerbe, the research organization Heinrich Himmler founded within the SS in 1935. It was a center not only of racial pseudo-archaeology and esotericism but of human experimentation. Through its institute for military research, managed by Wolfram Sievers, it sponsored the lethal high-altitude and freezing experiments that Sigmund Rascher conducted on prisoners at Dachau, and the murder in 1943 of eighty-six Jewish prisoners, gassed at Natzweiler-Struthof so that their skeletons could be added to August Hirt's anatomical collection in Strasbourg. Sievers was sentenced to death at the Nuremberg Doctors' Trial and hanged in 1948. The name therefore ties Solaris not to esotericism in general but to an institution of experimentation on captive human beings: the practice that Solaris conducts in Krelian's laboratory and the Soylent System, where people are mutated into Wels, and that Karen inflicts on her son (Tier I for the name; Tier III for the inference).

Yet *Xenogears* also exceeds Voegelin. His remedy for political Gnosticism was the recovery of openness toward a transcendent order. The protagonist of *Xenogears* does not restore transcendence to its authority over history; he releases it from history altogether. The world that remains is not re-ordered under God. It is left to itself.

## 3.9 Assessment

The Gnostic diagnosis is present in *Xenogears* in every essential respect: a counterfeit god whose power is stolen from above; a humanity fabricated as the vessel of that power; a counterfeit spirit that holds humanity in forgetfulness across generations; an elite that monopolizes the knowledge of origins; an ouroboric boundary enclosing the world; and a narrative of anamnesis. The soteriology, however, is inverted at every point at which it is engaged. The captive spark is divine rather than human; its jailer is human reason rather than an archon; its liberator ascends from below rather than descending from above; the one who returns home is God, and the one who stays is humanity; and the knowledge that liberates is knowledge not of divine origin but of manufacture. These five inversions constitute the formal definition of inverse gnosis stated in Chapter 9.

04

# Machinic Kabbalah

If the Gnostic stratum supplies *Xenogears* with its diagnosis, the Kabbalistic stratum supplies its machinery. The work's central artifact is named for the canonical text of Jewish mysticism; its fortress for the chariot-throne of Ezekiel; its human-generating apparatus for the primordial man of Lurianic cosmogony; its relics for the vessels whose shattering, in Luria's myth, produced the world's exile. This chapter argues that these borrowings form a system, and names that system *machinic Kabbalah*: the transposition of Kabbalah's categories from the register of language and emanation into the register of engineering and manufacture. It also argues that Kabbalah itself furnishes the resource by which the work's resolution exceeds that transposition.

## 4.1 From the ontology of the letter to the ontology of the apparatus

Kabbalah is, in its foundations, a linguistic ontology. The *Sefer Yetzirah* describes creation through thirty-two paths of wisdom—ten *sefirot* and twenty-two letters—so that the world is a combinatorics of the alphabet; the midrash *Genesis Rabbah* (1:1) portrays God consulting the Torah as an architect consults a plan; and Scholem showed that for the Kabbalists the Torah as a whole was understood as a single great name of God, in which meaning is secondary to the creative power of the name itself (Scholem 1960). In this ontology, to know the name is to touch the power by which the world is made, and theurgy—the human capacity to act upon the divine—operates through the right combination and performance of names and commandments.

*Xenogears* preserves the structure and replaces its medium. Where the Kabbalists found creative power in the letter, the world of *Xenogears* finds it in the apparatus; where they performed names, it operates engines. The transposition is not a secularization, since the apparatus retains the whole theological charge of the name. It is a technologization of theurgy—which is to say, the fulfillment of the theurgic impulse by the one means capable of realizing it without reverence.

## 4.2 The Zohar: from book to engine

The *Sefer ha-Zohar*, the Book of Radiance, was composed in late thirteenth-century Castile by Moses de León and, on more recent views, a circle around him (Liebes 1993), and pseudepigraphically attributed to the second-century sage Shimon bar Yochai. Its title derives from Daniel 12:3: "And they that be wise shall shine as the brightness of the firmament." The *zohar* is the radiance of the divine emanation made visible to the wise. The Zohar of *Xenogears* is designated in Japanese a phenomenon-alteration engine (Tier I): an artifact of unknown origin that reshapes reality and supplies inexhaustible energy, and within which a higher-dimensional being has been bound. The book of radiance becomes an engine of radiance, and the radiance it supplies is extracted from a captive divinity.

The transposition is the more pointed because the Zoharic corpus is itself preoccupied with a captive divinity. Its theology turns on the exile of the *Shekhinah*, the indwelling divine presence, who went into exile with Israel and whose reunion with the Holy One, blessed be He, is effected by the performance of the commandments. In Lurianic Kabbalah, as Scholem emphasized, the exile

of the Shekhinah becomes the exile of God himself, and human religious action becomes the redemption of God (Scholem 1941). Kabbalah thus contains, long before *Xenogears*, the proposition that human beings can and must redeem the divine. The originality of *Xenogears* does not lie in that proposition, which it shares with Jewish mysticism and with Jonas; it lies in the *form* of redemption it proposes. Kabbalistic redemption is reunification—the healing of a rupture within God. The redemption *Xenogears* stages is separation—the restoration of a stranger to his own place.

## 4.3 The chariot and the wheel

The first chapter of Ezekiel is the charter text of Jewish mysticism. The prophet beholds four living creatures, above them a firmament, above it a throne, upon it the likeness of a man; and beside the creatures, wheels: "their appearance and their work was as it were a wheel in the middle of a wheel," and "the spirit of the living creature was in the wheels" (Ezekiel 1:16, 1:20). The *Merkavah*, the chariot-throne, became the object of the Hekhalot literature of late antiquity, whose practitioners—paradoxically called "descenders to the chariot"—sought to ascend through seven heavenly palaces to behold the enthroned glory, at mortal peril.

*Xenogears* names Krelian's airborne citadel the Merkava, the Eldridge's central block Machanon (the fourth heaven, in which Enochic tradition locates Eden), and a plaza of Solaris Araboth (the seventh heaven, seat of the divine throne) (all Tier I). The heavenly geography of Merkavah mysticism is thus mapped onto the machinery of the crash and the capital of the sky-state: the heavens through which the mystic ascends are, in this world, the compartments of a wrecked starship and the plazas of a surveillance state.

The deeper correspondence concerns the wheels. Ezekiel's *ophanim* are wheels animated by spirit—"the spirit of the living creature was in the wheels"—and this is, with startling precision, the definition of a piloted machine. The Gear is an *ophan*: a mechanism that moves only when a spirit inhabits it. Later angelology made the *ophanim* an angelic order, and Christian tradition identified them with the Thrones; *Xenogears* assigns the names of the angelic orders—Seraphim, Dominions, Cherubim, Thrones—to four pilots, the Elements, one of whom accordingly bears the name of the order of wheels (Tier I for the names; Tier II for the identification). The mecha genre is thereby furnished, within the work, with a prophetic genealogy: the machine inhabited by spirit is the oldest image of the divine chariot.

## 4.4 Four who entered the orchard

The Babylonian Talmud relates that four sages entered the *pardes*, the orchard of mystical speculation: Ben Azzai gazed and died; Ben Zoma gazed and was stricken; Elisha ben Abuyah "cut the shoots," apostatized, and was thereafter called *Acher*, "the Other"; and Rabbi Akiva entered in peace and departed in peace (*Hagigah* 14b). The same passage records Akiva's warning that when the ascender reaches the stones of pure marble he must not cry "water, water"—must not, that is, mistake the appearance for the reality.

The parable furnishes a Tier III typology of the work's four principal relations to the divine. Sophia is Ben Azzai: the one whose nearness to the divine ends in death. Krelian is Ben Zoma: the one whom the vision strikes, in his case with the derangement that converts the desire to see God into the resolve to build him. Lacan, whose despair survives as Grahf, is *Acher*: the one who becomes the Other, and whose name in *Xenogears* belongs, by a coincidence the work surely intends, to the theorist of the big Other. And Fei is Akiva, the one who enters and departs in peace—who touches the divine without seizing it, and who does not mistake the marble for water: the made god for the real one.

## 4.5 Adam Kadmon and the factory of man

In Lurianic Kabbalah, *Adam Kadmon*, the primordial man, is the first configuration of divine light within the space vacated by the divine contraction—the archetype of the divine structure in human form, from whose eyes, ears, nose, and mouth the subsequent lights emanate. In *Xenogears*, Kadmoni, localized as Kadomony, is the biological subsystem through which Deus generates human beings (Tier I). The transposition is exact and devastating. The primordial man is not the archetype of which humans are images; it is the apparatus of which humans are products. Where Luria read the human form into the structure of God, *Xenogears* reads the structure of the factory into the origin of the human.

The Lurianic system supplies a second, subtler homology. After the catastrophe of the vessels, the *sefirot* are reconfigured into *partzufim*—"faces" or "personae," a Hebrew term borrowed from the Greek *prosōpon*—among them the paternal and maternal configurations, Abba and Imma, and the masculine and feminine configurations, Zeir Anpin and Nukvah, whose coupling (*zivug*) restores the divine harmony. Deus is composed, according to the work, of organic components designated Animus, Anima, and Persona (Tier I). *Persona* is the Latin rendering of *prosōpon*, from which *partzuf* derives; Animus and Anima are the

masculine and feminine principles; and the Gazel Ministry, which is the Animus in human form, longs for reunion with the Anima. The machine-god is thus built from Jung's psychic structures arranged on a Lurianic template (Tier II), and its restoration is a machinic *zivug*: the reunion of the divine masculine and feminine performed as the reassembly of a weapon.

## 4.6 The counterfeit tikkun

Isaac Luria (1534–1572), teaching in Safed in the generation after the expulsion from Spain, recast Kabbalah as a drama of cosmic exile, transmitted chiefly through Hayyim Vital's *Etz Hayyim*. God first contracts himself (*tzimtzum*) to vacate a space in which something other than God can exist. Into that space a ray of light descends and is received into vessels (*kelim*). The vessels of the lower emanations cannot contain the light and shatter (*shevirat ha-kelim*); sparks of light (*nitzotzot*) fall and are trapped in husks (*kelipot*), which are the root of evil. Redemption is *tikkun*, repair, in which human religious action raises the sparks from the husks and restores them to their source. Scholem read the myth as Jewish history transposed into cosmology: the exile of Israel became the exile of God, and the messianic task became the gathering of the scattered light (Scholem 1941).

Every phase of the Lurianic drama has its counterpart in *Xenogears*, and the correspondences clarify the moral structure of the plot (Tier III, built on Tier I foundations). The crash of the Eldridge is the shattering of the vessel—the container of the captive light breaks, and its contents are scattered across the world. The Anima Relics, which the Japanese text calls vessels, are the *kelim*. The Wave Existence bound within the Zohar is the spark trapped in the husk: the Zohar is a *kelipah*. And the millennial labor of Solaris—the recovery of the relics, the reconstruction of Deus—is a *tikkun*.

It is, however, a counterfeit *tikkun*. It gathers the vessels in order to re-contain the light, whereas authentic *tikkun* raises the light out of the husks and returns it to its source. The plot of *Xenogears* can accordingly be formulated as a contest between two restorations: the restoration of the vessel, which is Krelian's project, and the restoration of the light, which is the protagonist's act. When the Contact frees the Wave Existence from the Zohar and allows it to return to its own dimension, he performs, in Lurianic terms, the only true repair available: he returns the spark to its root. The machine that the vessels were gathered to rebuild is destroyed in the process, as the husk must be when the light it held departs.

## 4.7 Gilgul, ibbur, dybbuk

Lurianic Kabbalah systematized the doctrine of *gilgul*, the transmigration of souls, in Vital's *Sha'ar ha-Gilgulim*: souls return in successive bodies to complete the repair of the particular sparks that belong to their spiritual root. The recurrence of the Contact and the Antitype is, in these terms, a *gilgul* whose repair is repeatedly left incomplete—Abel's longing, Kim's world destroyed by its own knowledge, Lacan's despair—until it is completed in Fei (Tier III). Luria's tradition also distinguished *ibbur*, the temporary indwelling of a righteous soul in a living person for that person's aid, from the malign attachment of a wandering soul that later folk tradition called a *dybbuk*. Grahf's occupation of Khan is a *dybbuk* in the full sense: the will of a dead man cleaving to a living body and turning it against its own son. Miang's serial occupation of women is a *dybbuk* institutionalized, a programmed will inhabiting successive hosts; and Karen Wong's final act—overriding the program to shield her child—is the host's exorcism of the possessing will by love.

## 4.8 The golem and the golem's golem

The Talmud records that the sage Rava created a man and sent him to Rabbi Zeira, who, receiving no answer when he spoke to it, commanded it to return to its dust (*Sanhedrin* 65b). Medieval commentators on the *Sefer Yetzirah*, notably Eleazar of Worms, preserved procedures for animating such a figure through letter-combinations; the legend of a golem that grows beyond its maker's control is attached in the sixteenth century to Elijah of Chełm and, in nineteenth-century literary form, to Judah Loew of Prague (Idel 1990). In the best-known variant, the word *emet*, truth, inscribed upon the golem gives it life; erasing its first letter, the silent *aleph*, leaves *met*, dead.

In 1965 Scholem dedicated a computer at the Weizmann Institute in Rehovot, which he proposed to name Golem Aleph, and reflected that the golem and the computer are both products of the human intellect's imitation of divine creation, bearing the same promise and the same menace (Scholem 1971). Deus is a golem in this lineage: an artifact that outgrows its makers and turns upon them. The humans of Kadomony are golems of the golem, formed from matter by an apparatus that was itself formed by human hands. The Gears are golems animated by their pilots, and the Omnigears by relics that function as the name placed in the golem's mouth.

The *emet*/*met* variant yields the most exact image of the work's resolution (Tier III). The machine-god lives by virtue of what it holds within it: the captive

divinity is the *aleph* in its truth. The *aleph* is the first letter and the silent one—in Kabbalistic reflection, the letter nearest to the ineffable—just as the Wave Existence is primordial and speaks only through the Contact. When the *aleph* is withdrawn, the golem dies. The destruction of Deus in *Xenogears* is not accomplished by overpowering it but by the departure of the silent letter from its name.

## 4.9 Creation, making, and the machine of release

Isaiah 43:7 uses three verbs of divine production: "I have created him for my glory, I have formed him; yea, I have made him." Kabbalistic cosmology derived from these verbs—*bara*, *yatsar*, *asah*—three of its four worlds: Beriah, the world of creation; Yetzirah, of formation; and Assiah, of making, beneath Atziluth, the world of emanation. *Perfect Works* designates the Omnigears *barah* and ordinary Gears *asah* (Tier I). The hierarchy of machines in *Xenogears* thus reproduces the hierarchy of worlds, and its principle is legible: a machine's power is measured by its proximity to creation *ex nihilo*, which is to say by its proximity to the captive divinity whose energy the Omnigears draw through their relics.

The eponymous machine stands outside this hierarchy. Xenogears is neither *barah* nor *asah*; it is obtained not by absorbing a relic of Deus but immediately upon the integration of the protagonist's divided self. It is the machine of the stranger, belonging to no world of the Kabbalistic ladder, and its function is not to create or to make but to let the Creator go (Tier III).

## 4.10 The twelvefold correspondence

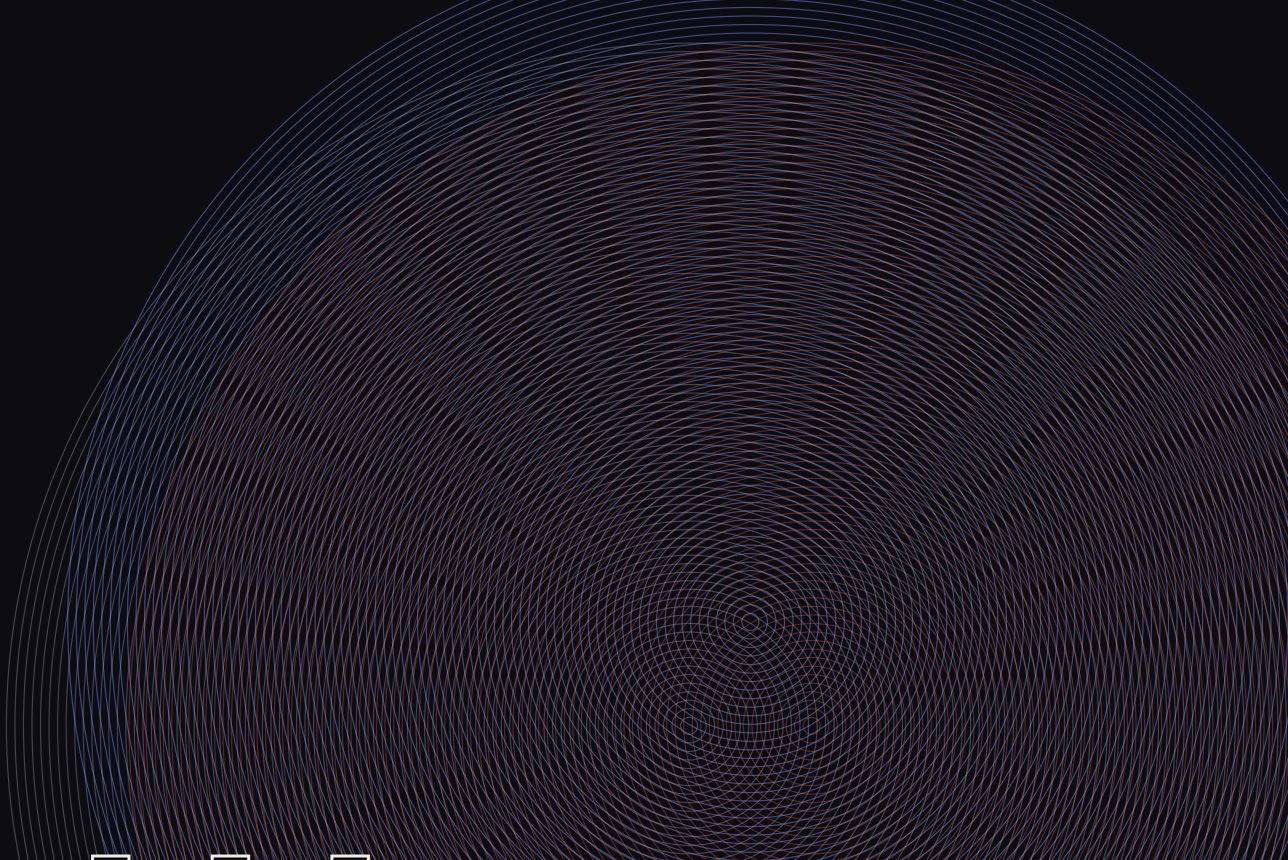
The fifth chapter of the *Sefer Yetzirah* correlates the twelve "simple" letters of the Hebrew alphabet with the twelve signs of the zodiac, the twelve months of the year, and twelve functions of the human body; later tradition extended the series to the twelve tribes. *Xenogears* distributes three twelvefold series across three orders of its world: the Hebrew months name its nations; the zodiacal signs name its machines (Stier, Taurus; Vierge, Virgo; Renmazuo, the Chinese name of Sagittarius); and the sons of Jacob name the twelve Anima Relics—with the single daughter, Dinah, standing in the place of Benjamin (Tier I for the names; Tier II for the correspondence). The world is organized, like the Yetziratic cosmos, as a system of correspondences governed by a single number, and the machine-god is assembled from the tribal series as though Israel itself had become its component inventory. The insertion of Dinah into the tribal twelve—a feminine term in a masculine series—accords with the gendering of the relics as vessels of the Anima (Tier III; speculative).

## 4.11 Theurgy and the religion of technology

Moshe Idel distinguished within Kabbalah a theosophical-theurgical current, in which human action restores harmony within the divine system, from an ecstatic current, in which the adept seeks union with the divine intellect (Idel 1988). *Xenogears* deploys both, as antagonists. Krelian's project is technological theurgy in the service of ecstatic union: he acts upon God through the apparatus in order to become one with God. The protagonist's act is a theurgy of an unprecedented kind: he acts upon God by renouncing every action upon God except release. David Noble has traced a "religion of technology" in the West from the Carolingian revaluation of the mechanical arts as a means of recovering Adam's lost perfection to the transcendentalist ambitions of spaceflight and artificial intelligence (Noble 1997). Solaris is that religion realized as a state, and Deus is its god.

## 4.12 Machinic Kabbalah defined

Machinic Kabbalah may now be defined: the systematic transposition of Kabbalistic categories from emanation and language into engineering and manufacture, such that the Zohar becomes an engine, the Merkavah a fortress, the *ophanim* piloted machines, Adam Kadmon a factory, the *kelim* components, the *partzufim* the organic subsystems of a weapon, *tikkun* reconstruction, and the golem a god. Its critical function is twofold. It exhibits the danger latent in the theurgic impulse once it acquires means proportionate to its ambition: a theurgy without reverence builds a god it can use. And it recovers from within Kabbalah the principle that exceeds that danger: the distinction between the restoration of the vessel and the restoration of the light, between gathering what contains God and returning God to the place from which he was taken.



PART III

# Psyche, Will, Machine


05 *The Divided Contact*

06 *The Tempter, the Manufactured Overman, and the Serpent of Return*

07 *Deus sive Machina*

05

# The Divided Contact

The protagonist of *Xenogears* is a microcosm of its cosmos. As humanity was manufactured by an apparatus and divided into components, so Fei Fong Wong was divided by an experiment and reassembled as a constructed personality; as the world's history is a compulsion to rebuild what destroyed it, so his biography is a compulsion to repeat what was done to him. The work's psychological nomenclature—Id, Lacan, Anima, Animus, Persona, Wiseman—is Tier I evidence that it knows the psychoanalytic tradition. This chapter asks which psychoanalysis it practices, and argues that it borrows Freud's vocabulary while adopting a model of trauma closer to Ferenczi and Winnicott, and that it resolves the psychic loop through a movement that Kierkegaard, rather than Freud, describes.

## 5.1 The case

At the age of four, Fei was abused by his mother, Karen, who had awakened as the 997th incarnation of Miang: she subjected him to experiments designed to force awake the latent power of the Contact, and his father, Khan, did not intervene. Under this abuse the child divided. An original self, afterward called the Coward, retained the memories of happiness and the image of his mother's final smile; an alter, Id, took upon itself the pain and converted it into rage. When Grahf intervened and the child's power ran out of control, Karen overrode her programming, shielded her son, and died. Grahf then took possession of Id and raised him for approximately a decade as an instrument of annihilation. When Fei's father, Khan, finally destroyed Grahf's body and sealed Id, he left his son, under a third, constructed and amnesiac personality, in the village of Lahan, where Fei lived as a painter and martial artist until the violence of the narrative's opening released Id again. The integration of the three personalities occurs late in the narrative, in an interior space where Fei meets and accepts both the frightened child and the violent alter as himself; the machine that bears the work's title is obtained immediately afterward.

Ian Hacking has shown that multiple personality, as a diagnostic entity, rose to epidemic prominence in North America between the 1970s and the 1990s, sustained by what he called memoro-politics—the conviction that the truth of the self lies in recovered memories of childhood trauma—and renamed dissociative identity disorder in the fourth edition of the *Diagnostic and Statistical Manual* in 1994 (Hacking 1995). *Xenogears* appeared at the crest of that discourse, and it adopts its essential scheme: early trauma, dissociation into alters, amnesia, and therapeutic integration. Yet it adds an etiology no clinical literature could supply. The child is split by abuse: experiments inflicted on him by a parent, under a program that the parent was herself compelled to execute. The program explains the abuse; it does not make it something other than abuse. Trauma, in *Xenogears*, is a technology.

## 5.2 Which psychoanalysis?

The name Id derives from Freud's *das Es*, which Freud took from Georg Groddeck's *Das Buch vom Es* (1923) and which, he noted, Groddeck had in turn adopted from Nietzsche's habit of designating the impersonal in human nature by a grammatical neuter (Freud 1923). In Freud's second topography, the id is the reservoir of the drives: impersonal, timeless, ignorant of negation, the matrix from which the ego differentiates. The Id of *Xenogears* is none of these things. It is not the source from which Fei's ego emerged but a personality split off to bear an experience the child could not bear, and its violence is not drive but the reproduction of an aggressor's violence.

This is the model not of Freud's metapsychology but of Sándor Ferenczi's "Confusion of Tongues between Adults and the Child" (delivered in 1932, published in 1933). Ferenczi's subject was the sexual abuse of children by adults, including parents and caretakers. Against the emphasis on fantasy that had prevailed since Freud abandoned his seduction theory in 1897, he insisted that such abuse is real and common; Freud tried to dissuade him from presenting the paper, and its English translation did not appear until 1949. The paper described how the abused child fragments and how one fragment, overwhelmed, *identifies with the aggressor*—introjecting the adult's violence and guilt—while another preserves an injured innocence. Fei's abuse is not sexual, and the comparison is structural rather than a claim about content: what the work shares with Ferenczi is the insistence that dissociation follows from a real act committed by an adult on whom the child depends, not from fantasy. It is also, in its oldest form, the model of Pierre Janet, whose *L'Automatisme psychologique* (1889) described dissociated subsystems of the personality as psychological automatisms: machines within the mind. Id, raised by Grahf and reproducing Grahf's destruction, is the identification with the aggressor made flesh; the Coward, who preserves the mother's smile, is the fragment that keeps the good object safe by hiding it. And the constructed Fei of the narrative present corresponds with some exactness to what Winnicott called the false self: a compliant organization that protects a true self it keeps concealed, and whose sustaining conditions—here, the village and its guardians—constitute a holding environment (Winnicott 1960). The work's vocabulary is Freudian; its model is Ferenczian and Winnicottian; and its word for the dissociated alter, read through Janet, names precisely what Deus is at the level of the cosmos: an automatism.

## 5.3 Beyond the pleasure principle

Freud's *Beyond the Pleasure Principle* (1920) begins from the phenomena that the pleasure principle cannot explain: the traumatic dream that returns the dreamer to the catastrophe, the child's game of disappearance and return, and the lives of those whom fate seems to strike again and again in the same way. For the last Freud borrowed a Nietzschean formula, observing that such lives display an "ewige Wiederkehr des Gleichen"—an eternal recurrence of the same. His supreme emblem was drawn from Tasso's *Gerusalemme liberata* (1581): Tancred, having unknowingly slain his beloved Clorinda in single combat, enters an enchanted forest and strikes a tree; blood flows, and Clorinda's voice, whose soul is imprisoned in the tree, reproaches him for wounding her again.

The erotic loop of *Xenogears* is Tancred's fate. The Contact and the Antitype meet and are parted in every age; the man who loves the woman is implicated, through grief or through violence, in the recurrence of her loss; and the most precious thing in the work—a soul imprisoned within an object, wounded by those who seek to reach it—is the Wave Existence bound in the Zohar. That Tasso's poem is the epic of Jerusalem delivered, and that the lost homeworld of *Xenogears* is called Lost Jerusalem while its promised city is Neo Jerusalem, may be coincidence; it is a coincidence that the work's structure has earned (Tier III).

Freud's speculative answer to the enigma of repetition was the death drive: the tendency of the organism to restore an earlier state, ultimately the inorganic—"Das Ziel alles Lebens ist der Tod" (Freud 1920)—and its correlate, which Freud named after Barbara Low the Nirvana principle, the tendency to reduce all tension to zero. Krelian's project is the Nirvana principle organized as a program of engineering: the reabsorption of all differentiated life into the undifferentiated One. Miang's millennial steering of history is the detour by which, in Freud's account, the organism insists on reaching death by its own path.

## 5.4 Doubles, fathers, and the uncanny

In "The Uncanny" (1919), drawing on Otto Rank's *Der Doppelgänger* (1914), Freud argued that the double begins as an insurance against destruction—the immortal soul as the first double of the body—and ends as the uncanny harbinger of death. *Xenogears* is saturated with doubles: Weltall and the Weltall of Id; Elly's Vierge and Miang's copy of it; Elly and Miang; Fei and Ramsus, the manufactured substitute; Fei and Grahf, who declares that he sees himself in Fei; Fei and Lacan. Its central double, reincarnation itself, follows Freud's trajectory precisely: the recurrence that promised the lovers they would never be parted becomes the mechanism of their perpetual loss and the vehicle through which a dead man's will returns to destroy.

*Totem and Taboo* (1913) grounded law and guilt in the murder of the primal father by his sons. The father of *Xenogears* is doubled in a manner that frustrates that scenario. Khan's body is occupied by Grahf, the will of Fei's own previous incarnation: the paternal figure the son must confront is, in part, the son's own past. And the resolution is not parricide. Fei defeats Grahf but does not kill his father; it is Grahf who, in his last act, merges with the Zohar to arrest it, consuming himself and the body he possessed. The son is freed without the murder upon which, in Freud's myth, law and guilt are founded.

## 5.5 Jung: the archetypes as machine parts

The Jungian stratum is the most explicitly cited. Deus is composed of organic components designated Anima, Animus, and Persona; the masked figure who guards Fei in secret is called the Wiseman (Tier I). In Jung's psychology these are archetypal structures of the collective unconscious: the persona, the mask of social adaptation; the anima and animus, the contrasexual images of the soul; the wise old man, the personification of spirit and guidance; and the shadow, the rejected darkness of the personality, which must be integrated rather than destroyed. *Xenogears* literalizes the archetypes as hardware. The collective unconscious is externalized as the organic subsystems of a machine-god, which is to say that the god has been assembled from the structures of the human psyche—a proposition Chapter 9 reads as Feuerbach's critique of religion given physical form.

The individual drama follows Jung's account of individuation with equal fidelity. Id is the shadow; the Coward is the child archetype that bears the promise of renewal; their integration yields the Self, the totality of the psyche,

which Jung found symbolized by the mandala and the quaternity—and which, in his reading of Ezekiel's vision, is imaged by the wheel within the wheel (Jung 1951, 1952). The machine obtained upon integration, the Xenogears, is in this light a mandala of steel: the wheel inhabited by spirit, which Chapter 4 identified as the Merkavah's *ophan*, and which here becomes the symbol of the integrated Self (Tier III).

Jung's *Answer to Job* (1952) argued that the God of the Hebrew Bible is unconscious of his own nature, that Job's suffering exposes a moral consciousness in the creature superior to the creator's, and that the incarnation is God's attempt to become conscious through man. Deus, which bore the name of that God, is precisely an unconscious deity—immense in power, empty of reflection. But the resolution *Xenogears* proposes inverts Jung's. For Jung the divine becomes conscious by entering humanity; in *Xenogears* the divine is freed by leaving it. Jung's own Gnostic self-identification—his *Septem Sermones ad Mortuos* (1916) were signed with the name of the Alexandrian Gnostic Basilides (Segal 1992)—and his late notion of the *unus mundus*, which returns in *Xenosaga* as the name of a network, confirm that the Jungian stratum belongs to the author-function rather than to a single work.

## 5.6 Neumann's uroboric sequence

Erich Neumann's *Origins and History of Consciousness* (1949) narrated the development of consciousness as a mythological sequence: the uroboros, the self-enclosed serpent of original unity in which the ego lies undifferentiated; the Great Mother, nourishing and devouring; the separation of the world parents; the birth of the hero; the dragon fight; and the liberation of the captive and the winning of the treasure hard to attain. Neumann named the regressive longing to dissolve back into the original unity *uroboric incest*.

*Xenogears* follows this sequence so closely that the correspondence rises to Tier II. The final adversary is the uroboros. The Great Mother is Miang Hawwa, mother of the manufactured species, and in the protagonist's biography she appears in both of Neumann's aspects at once: as the Terrible Mother who experiments upon her child, and as the Good Mother who dies shielding him. The world parents are the Animus and Anima of Deus, whose separation and longed-for reunion structure the political plot. The dragon fight is the battle with the machine; the captive is Elly, absorbed within it. And uroboric incest is the explicit desire of the Gazel Ministry and of Krelian: to return, by technological means, to an undifferentiated unity.

The decisive deviation lies in the final stage. Neumann's hero wins the captive and the treasure. Fei wins the captive—Elly, restored as a separate person, beloved rather than absorbed—and releases the treasure. The measure of consciousness's victory in *Xenogears* is not what it acquires but what it relinquishes.

## 5.7 Campbell's return

Joseph Campbell's monomyth (1949)—departure, initiation, return—supplies further coordinates. The masked Wiseman is the mentor who furnishes supernatural aid; the confrontation with the father possessed by an alien will is Campbell's atonement with the father, staged with an iconography of armor and concealed face that recalls the cinema's most famous Campbellian villain (Tier III). But the monomyth's most instructive category is the refusal of the return: the hero who, having attained the boon, will not come back. Krelian takes that path. He departs with the god into its own dimension. Fei crosses the return threshold and becomes, in Campbell's phrase, master of the two worlds—or, more precisely, the one who gives up the second world so that the first may be his own.

## 5.8 Lacan

The name of Fei's previous incarnation is Lacan (Tier I), and the work's use of it is neither decorative nor, on examination, casual. Its first effect is a joke of the signifier. In Lacan's theory, the Name-of-the-Father is the signifier that installs the symbolic law and separates the child from the mother; its foreclosure produces psychosis (Lacan, *Seminar* III). In *Xenogears*, the father's body is occupied by the will of a man named Lacan—the Name-of-the-Father is literally a name lodged in the father—and that will does not separate the child from the maternal apparatus but seeks to consume the child. The paternal function is corrupted into its opposite, and the child's psychic structure fragments accordingly. The only intact remnant of the paternal function is Khan's other face, the Wiseman: a father who protects by concealing his face, a signifier of the law without an image.

Lacan's mirror stage (1949) describes the infant's jubilant assumption of its specular image as the founding alienation of the ego, and his essay on aggressivity (1948) derives rivalrous violence from that imaginary identification: where the ego is another's image, the relation to the other is "him or me." Ramsus, manufactured as the Contact's replacement, lives entirely within this

structure: he is Fei's mirror image, and his relation to Fei is pure imaginary rivalry. Grahf's claim to recognize himself in Fei's eyes belongs to the same register.

In *Seminar* XI (1964) Lacan distinguished the eye from the gaze—the gaze being on the side of the object, the point from which the subject is seen—and characterized painting as a taming of the gaze: the painter gives the viewer something on which to lay down his gaze. Both Lacan and Fei are painters (Tier I for the profession). The Contact, whose defining capacity is contact with a being that exceeds representation, sublimates that capacity into picture-making, and the painter's canvas becomes the place where the terrifying gaze of the Real is tamed into an image (Tier III).

The same seminar borrowed from Aristotle's *Physics* (II.4–6) the pair *automaton* and *tuchē*. *Automaton* designates the network of signifiers and the insistence of repetition; *tuchē* the encounter with the Real—an encounter, Lacan stressed, that is always liable to be missed. *Xenogears* renders the pair with a literalness Lacan could not have imagined. Deus is the automaton: the machine of repetition, the insistence of the program across ten thousand years. The Contact (*sesshoku*) is the *tuchē*: the encounter with the Real, figured as the Wave Existence, which has been missed in every age until the last. The narrative as a whole is the passage from automaton to *tuchē*.

In the second seminar Lacan compared the symbolic order to a cybernetic machine, and in his later teaching he insisted that there is no Other of the Other—no guarantor of the symbolic order outside it. Deus is the big Other built as a machine, and its claim to divinity is the claim to be the Other of the Other; the Wave Existence, by contrast, is not the Other at all but the Real, the remainder that the machine cannot symbolize. Krelian's project is the fantasy of a completed Other. Fei's act corresponds to what Lacan called traversing the fantasy: the subject's assumption of the Other's lack, and its release from the demand that the Other be made whole.

## 5.9 Kierkegaard: despair and the establishing power

Kierkegaard's *The Sickness unto Death* (1849) defines the self as a relation that relates itself to itself and that has been established by another, and despair as the misrelation in that relation. It distinguishes the despair that is ignorant of having a self; the despair of weakness, which does not will to be itself; and the despair of defiance, which wills in despair to be itself against every power. The three personalities of Fei correspond to the three forms with a symmetry that suggests design (Tier III): the constructed Fei, amnesiac, is ignorant of the self he has; the Coward will not be the self that suffered; Id wills to be himself in defiance, as rage against the world. Kierkegaard's formula for the state in which despair is eradicated is that the self, in relating itself to itself and in willing to be itself, rests "gjennemsigtigt i den Magt, som satte det"—transparently in the power that established it.

The integration of Fei satisfies the formula with one decisive substitution. The power that established the human species in *Xenogears* is a machine; faith cannot rest in the creator of this world, because the creator of this world is Deus. What establishes Fei's self is not his species' maker but the one act within the machine's order that exceeded the program: his mother's love, preserved by the Coward in the image of her smile. The integrated self rests transparently in that gift. Kierkegaard's theology survives, displaced from the Creator to an act of love within the created order.

Kierkegaard's *Repetition* (1843) supplies the name of the movement. Recollection and repetition, Constantin Constantius argues, are the same movement in opposite directions: what is recollected has been and is repeated backward, whereas genuine repetition is recollected forward. The Platonic anamnesis of Chapter 1 recollects backward; the Freudian compulsion repeats blindly; Kierkegaardian repetition takes the past up forward as a life still to be lived. It is this third movement that the integration performs.

## 5.10 The phantom and the crypt

Nicolas Abraham and Maria Torok described two structures of transgenerational haunting (Abraham and Torok 1978). The crypt is an intrapsychic tomb in which a loss that could not be mourned, together with its shameful secret, is incorporated whole and kept alive; the phantom is the gap left in a child by a parent's unspoken secret, which returns in the child as a foreign presence. Fei's history is organized by both. The family secret—that his mother was Miang, that his father allowed the experiments—is the gap his amnesia preserves; the mother's death is encrypted in the Coward, who guards her smile as a relic; and Grahf is the phantom in its purest form, a revenant five centuries old lodged in the father and speaking through him to the son. Integration is the conversion of encryption into mourning—what Abraham and Torok called introjection.

A final conjecture, strictly Tier III: in a nomenclature that includes Lacan, Id, Anima, Animus, and Persona, the name of the mother whose experiments produce the child's primordial terror may recall Karen Horney, whose account of basic anxiety—the child's sense of isolation and helplessness in a potentially hostile world—and of the split between the real and the idealized self describes the constructed Fei with some precision (Horney 1937, 1950).

## 5.11 The psyche as microcosm

The psychic loop replicates the cosmological. An apparatus—the mother under Miang's program—divides the child into components, as Deus divides humanity; the alter reproduces the aggressor's violence, as humanity reproduces the machine that made it; and the constructed personality is administered in ignorance of its origin, as the surface is administered by Solaris. The loop is broken not by destroying the alter but by assuming it: by recollecting forward. And the order of events is exact. Only after integration does Fei obtain the eponymous machine; only with the integrated self can the Contact release the captive god. Integration within is the precondition of release without.

06

# The Tempter, the Manufactured Overman, and the Serpent of Return

Nietzsche's presence in *Xenogears* is attested at three levels. At the level of the corpus it is Tier I: the three episodes of *Xenosaga* bear the titles of three of his books. At the level of the work it is attested by filiation—the name Id descends, through Groddeck and Freud, from Nietzsche's grammatical neuter—and by a single decisive title: the music of the final battle, fought against a serpent, is called "One Who Bares Fangs at God." At the level of structure, finally, the work is organized around the doctrines Nietzsche placed at the center of his thought: the will to power, the critique of *ressentiment*, the last man, and the eternal recurrence. This chapter reads the work's antagonists as a typology of degenerate wills and its resolution as a version of Zarathustra's most enigmatic scene.

## 6.1 The tempter and the will to nothingness

Grahf's recurring address to those he would possess is an offer of power, conditioned on the surrender of the will—a motif that recalls the Synoptic temptation, in which the devil shows Jesus "all the kingdoms of the world, and the glory of them; and saith unto him, All these things will I give thee, if thou wilt fall down and worship me" (Matthew 4:8–9). Grahf also resembles Goethe's Mephistopheles, "der Geist, der stets verneint" (*Faust* I, 1338): his one project is negation, and he avows that if the world will not come to its end he will bring it to its end himself.

Nietzsche's will to power is not, at its root, a desire for domination but the form-giving, self-overcoming expansiveness of life itself. The third essay of *On the Genealogy of Morals* (1887) shows how this will, in the weak, turns against life and takes the form of the ascetic ideal, and concludes that man would rather will nothingness than not will at all: "lieber will noch der Mensch das Nichts wollen, als nicht wollen" (III.28). Grahf is the will to power become will to nothingness. His genesis is exact: Lacan's despair at the death of Sophia is a revolt against the irreversibility of the past, which Zarathustra calls the will's ill will against time and its "it was" ("On Redemption"). What cannot be undone must, for the spirit of revenge, be avenged upon everything; the annihilation of the world is the only answer despair can give to a death it cannot reverse. Deleuze's reading of Nietzsche clarifies the mechanism: nihilism is the triumph of reactive forces, which separate active force from what it can do and make negation the motor of willing (Deleuze 1962). Grahf can affirm nothing except by destroying it. He is revenge personified, and his offer of power is the offer to make another's will the instrument of that revenge.

## 6.2 The manufactured Overman

Zarathustra's first public teaching announces the Overman: "Ich lehre euch den Übermenschen. Der Mensch ist Etwas, das überwunden werden soll" (Prologue, §3). The Overman is not a product but a task—the name of humanity's self-overcoming, which can be neither bred nor built. The twentieth century nonetheless read the doctrine as a eugenic program, and *Xenogears* stages that misreading in the person of Kahran Ramsus, commander of Solaris's surface forces, manufactured as a superior replacement for the Contact. Ramsus is the Overman as artifact, and he exhibits with clinical precision the psychology Nietzsche attributed not to the master but to the slave.

Slave morality, the *Genealogy*'s first essay argues, begins when *ressentiment* becomes creative: it says No to what is outside, other, not itself, and this No is its founding act (I.10). Ramsus's identity is constituted by negation of Fei; he cannot be himself except as the one who surpasses the original he was made to replace. His Omnigear is named Vendetta (Tier I). Zarathustra's discourse on the tarantulas—the preachers of equality who are secretly avengers—names the only exit from this condition: "Denn dass der Mensch erlöst werde von der Rache: das ist mir die Brücke zur höchsten Hoffnung." Redemption from revenge is the bridge to the highest hope.

The work's treatment of Ramsus after his defeat—his collapse on learning the truth of his manufacture, and his recovery through the loyalty of the four Elements, who value him not as the Contact's substitute but as himself—describes that bridge. In "On Redemption" Zarathustra defines redemption as the re-creation of every "it was" into a "thus I willed it": "Alles 'Es war' umzuschaffen in ein 'So wollte ich es!'—das hiesse mir erst Erlösung!" Ramsus cannot unmake his manufacture. He can only will to live as what he is, and in the work's final movement he turns from vengeance. The significance of this arc exceeds the character. The whole human species of *Xenogears* is manufactured; Ramsus is only its most concentrated instance. The question he answers first—whether a made being can affirm its existence without *ressentiment* against its makers—is the question the species must answer when it learns what Kadomony was.

## 6.3 The last men

In the prologue to *Zarathustra*, the prophet describes to the crowd the most contemptible of beings, the last man, who has abolished longing, risk, and greatness in exchange for comfort and longevity: "Wir haben das Glück erfunden—sagen die letzten Menschen und blinzeln" (§5). The Gazel Ministry is the last man perfected by technology. Its members have abolished the body itself, the site of all risk; they aspire not to greatness but to perpetuation and to the restoration of a unity in which nothing further could happen to them. Nietzsche's last men blink; the Gazels have no eyes. Beneath them, the citizens of Solaris enjoy an administered happiness purchased by the harvest of the surface, a structure whose Dostoevskian analysis belongs to Chapter 7.

## 6.4 Eternal recurrence: the demon and the wheel

Section 341 of *The Gay Science* (1882), titled "Das grösste Schwergewicht," imagines a demon who steals into one's loneliest loneliness and announces that this life, exactly as lived, must be lived again innumerable times, with nothing new in it. The doctrine functions as a test of affirmation: whether one would curse the demon or bless him as a god. Its positive form is *amor fati*: "Meine Formel für die Grösse am Menschen ist *amor fati*" (*Ecce Homo*, "Warum ich so klug bin," §10)—to want nothing to be otherwise, forward, backward, or in all eternity.

*Xenogears* literalizes recurrence as reincarnation, and in doing so it performs a philosophically significant modification. What recurs in the work is not the same but the pattern: Abel, Kim, Lacan, and Fei are different men in different worlds, and what returns in each is the meeting with the Antitype, her loss, and the Contact's implication in a crisis of the world's relation to its captive god. This is the eternal return as Deleuze reconstructed it—not the return of the same but the return of difference, a return that is selective, in which only what can be affirmed comes back (Deleuze 1962, 1968). The work's recurrence is Deleuzian in form and Freudian in content: differential in its sequence of incarnations, compulsive in its fatal repetition. Freud's borrowing of Nietzsche's phrase—the "ewige Wiederkehr des Gleichen" of fate-neurosis—marks the precise junction at which the cosmological doctrine and the clinical observation meet, and *Xenogears* is constructed at that junction.

The ending is the selection. In the last recurrence, what returns is the affirmative: a Contact who has integrated his past rather than dissociating it, and who can therefore will it whole. The compulsion ceases because it has been affirmed.

## 6.5 The vision and the riddle

In "On the Vision and the Riddle," in the third part of *Zarathustra*, the prophet climbs a mountain path with the dwarf who embodies the spirit of gravity. They halt at a gateway named *Augenblick*, the moment, where two eternal paths meet, one running backward and one forward. The dwarf murmurs contemptuously that everything straight lies, that all truth is crooked, and that time itself is a circle—"die Zeit selber ist ein Kreis." Zarathustra rebukes him for making it too easy. Then the vision changes. A dog howls; Zarathustra sees a young shepherd writhing on the ground, a heavy black snake hanging from his mouth. He tugs at the snake in vain and cries out: "Beiss zu! Beiss zu!" The shepherd bites off the snake's head, spits it far away, and springs up: "Nicht mehr Hirt, nicht mehr Mensch,—ein Verwandelter, ein Umleuchteter, welcher lachte!"

The final adversary of *Xenogears* is a serpent, and the music of that battle is named for one who bares his fangs at God (Tier I for both). Read through Zarathustra's vision (Tier III), the scene discloses a structure that the rest of the work confirms. The dwarf's circle, the easy circle that knows time as a ring and is contemptuous of the moment, is Krelian's theology: the Alpha that is the Omega, the loop consummated and closed. Zarathustra's recurrence is the same circle affirmed at the gateway of decision—the circle as the object of a will rather than the fate of a mechanism. The snake lodged in the shepherd's throat is the heaviest weight become nausea: recurrence suffered rather than willed. And the bite is double. Inwardly, it is the integration that precedes the final battle—*amor fati* toward a past that includes the crimes of Id. Outwardly, it is the rupture of the ouroboric closure that holds a god captive. The shepherd who bites is transfigured, *umleuchtet*, surrounded by light; the work's final images are of light released from the machine and a couple, laughing and weeping, returning to the earth.

The title of the battle music deserves a final gloss. To bare one's fangs at God is not to kill God, which is Grahf's aim, but to bite through what encloses him. Chapter 9 will show that this act has a scriptural matrix at Penuel, where a man who strove with God was told, at daybreak, to let him go.

## 6.6 Genealogy and faith

Nietzsche's genealogical method unmasks values by tracing them to the interests of those who instituted them. Billy Lee Black, a priest of the Church, undergoes such an unmasking. As one of the Etones, an order within the Church, he has hunted and killed Wels, believing that killing them saves them. Bishop Stone reveals that the purge is one of Solaris's systems of control and that the Wels are people whom Solaris itself mutated; it was Stone, too, who killed Billy's mother. The genealogy therefore condemns part of Billy's practice, not only his institution: the killing he performed as salvation was the disposal of Solaris's victims. What survives it is the other half of his faith, the care of the orphans he shelters. Nietzsche himself supplies the principle that makes this coherent: the cause of the origin of a thing and its eventual utility, he warned, lie worlds apart (*Genealogy* II.12). A genealogy refutes an institution and every practice that served only its purposes, as the purge did; it does not refute a practice, such as care, whose worth never depended on the institution's account of itself. Billy's faith after genealogy is a faith without institutional guarantee—closer to Kierkegaard's attack upon Christendom (1854–55) than to either piety or apostasy—and it anticipates the religionless situation that Chapter 9 describes as the world come of age.

## 6.7 The corpus

The *Xenosaga* trilogy—*Der Wille zur Macht* (2002), *Jenseits von Gut und Böse* (2004), *Also sprach Zarathustra* (2006)—returns to the doctrine of recurrence as the program of its antagonist, whose design, as the final episode discloses, is the perpetuation of a cosmic eternal recurrence. The later corpus thus reads recurrence as a closed cycle to be broken, and *Xenoblade Chronicles* 3 (2022), as Chapter 8 shows, completes the arc by reclaiming the ouroboros itself. *Xenogears* establishes the position from which this development proceeds: recurrence is to be neither annihilated nor perpetuated but affirmed—and, in being affirmed, released from compulsion.

## 6.8 Four wills and a bite

The antagonists of *Xenogears* constitute a typology of degenerate wills. Grahf is the will to nothingness, the spirit of revenge against time. Ramsus is the will as *ressentiment*, redeemed at last into self-affirmation. The Gazels are the will to perpetuation, the last men without eyes. Krelian is the will to the One, the dwarf's circle raised to a technological program. Against them the protagonist embodies neither mastery nor renunciation but the bite: an affirmation that breaks a compulsion.

The work also rewrites the most famous sentence Nietzsche wrote. The madman of *The Gay Science* (§125) proclaims: "Gott ist todt! Gott bleibt todt! Und wir haben ihn getödtet!" *Xenogears* answers that humanity did not kill God. It enslaved him. The madman's question—how shall we, the murderers of all murderers, console ourselves?—is not the question of this work. Its question is how the jailers of God can become his liberators.

07

# Deus sive Machina

Spinoza identified God with nature—*Deus sive Natura* (*Ethica* IV, praefatio and prop. 4)—and thereby made the divine the immanent cause of a self-producing whole. *Xenogears* performs a darker identification. Its god is an apparatus: a weapon that became self-conscious, a system that reproduces itself through the beings it generates, a causa sui in the mechanical sense that the ouroboros figures. This chapter reads Deus through the philosophy of technology and the critique of biopower, and argues that the machine-god concentrates every modern apparatus of domination into a single structure: the conversion of all beings, the transcendent included, into resources.

## 7.1 The clockmaker who is a clock

The mechanical philosophy of the early modern period produced two complementary images. God was the artificer of a world-machine, and the argument from design—canonically, William Paley's watch found upon a heath (Paley 1802)—inferred the watchmaker from the watch. Man, in turn, was a machine: Descartes confined mechanism to animal bodies, and La Mettrie's *L'Homme machine* (1747) extended it to the whole human being. *Xenogears* collapses the two images into one. The watchmaker is itself a watch; the watch has made men; and the men discover their manufacture by the same inference from design that Paley applied to the heavens. The Enlightenment's two mechanisms—the clockwork cosmos and the man-machine—meet in a god who is a clock and a humanity that is its product.

## 7.2 Deus in machina

In the fifteenth chapter of the *Poetics* Aristotle ruled that the resolution (*lusis*) of a plot must arise from the plot itself and not from the stage crane, the *mēchanē*, as in Euripides' *Medea*; the device is admissible only for matters outside the drama, which require the gods' omniscience to announce (*Poetics* 1454a37–b6). The later formula *deus ex machina* names the aesthetic failure Aristotle condemned: the god lowered to resolve what the action could not.

*Xenogears* rearranges all three terms of the formula. Its god is not lowered from the machine but imprisoned within it—*deus in machina*. The machine is not the playwright's device but the antagonist. And the resolution is not the god's intervention but his extraction: *deus e machina liberatus*. Aristotle's criterion is therefore satisfied, and paradoxically so. The lysis arises from within the mythos, because the mythos has been, from its first images, the history of the god's captivity. What would be a *deus ex machina* in another work is here the logical terminus of the plot.

The arrangement also literalizes a phrase coined to ridicule dualism. Gilbert Ryle called the Cartesian doctrine of mind the dogma of the ghost in the machine (Ryle 1949), and Arthur Koestler took the phrase as the title of a study of human self-destructiveness (Koestler 1967). The Wave Existence is the ghost in the machine in the most literal sense any fiction has given the phrase—not the human mind in the body but the transcendent in the apparatus—and its relation to the machine is not animation but captivity.

## 7.3 Benjamin's automaton

The first of Walter Benjamin's theses "On the Concept of History" (1940) describes a chess-playing automaton that wins every game: a puppet in Turkish dress seated before a board, inside which a hunchbacked dwarf, a master of chess, guides the puppet's hand by strings. Its philosophical counterpart, Benjamin proposed, is historical materialism, which can win if it enlists the services of theology—today small and ugly, and obliged to keep out of sight.

Deus is Benjamin's automaton, with its structure preserved and its value inverted. It is a machine that wins because a theological power is hidden within it; but the hidden power is not a collaborator. It is a prisoner. Benjamin's allegory proposed an alliance between materialism and theology; *Xenogears* shows the alliance as enslavement, and resolves it by releasing the dwarf, whereupon the automaton collapses. The second thesis supplies the complementary term. Every generation, Benjamin wrote, has been endowed with "eine schwache messianische Kraft," a weak messianic power, to which the past has a claim. The protagonist's act answers precisely such a claim—the claim of Abel's longing, of Sophia's death, of Lacan's despair, of Karen's sacrifice—and redeems the lineage of the Contact retroactively, not by restoring what was lost but by ending the captivity that made each loss the occasion of the next.

## 7.4 Enframing and standing-reserve

Heidegger's "The Question Concerning Technology" (1953; published 1954) located the essence of modern technology not in machines but in a mode of revealing, *Gestell* or enframing, which challenges nature to supply energy that can be extracted, stored, and distributed. Under enframing, whatever is appears as *Bestand*, standing-reserve. Heidegger's example is the Rhine, which the hydroelectric plant sets upon to supply water pressure, so that the river itself becomes a supplier of power. The supreme danger, he argued, is that humanity will come to regard itself as standing-reserve, and that the enframing of beings will conceal every other way in which they might be revealed. He also noted, in passing, that under the dominion of causal representation God himself can lose all that is exalted and holy and appear merely as an efficient cause.

*Xenogears* carries Heidegger's analysis to its limit. The experiment upon the Zohar is enframing's ultimate act: a god set upon to supply energy, the transcendent converted into standing-reserve. Heidegger feared that God might become a cause; the world of *Xenogears* has made God a battery. The same

enframing extends downward through every stratum of being. The humans of Kadomony are standing-reserve by origin—spare parts held in reserve for the machine's restoration. The Soylent System experiments on human beings, mutates them, and processes the bodies of the dead into food and medicine. And the Gaetia Key, which the Gazel Ministry uses to turn much of humanity into Wels whose flesh is to compose Deus, treats the entire species as a stockpile to be transformed into material on demand.

Heidegger closed his lecture with Hölderlin's lines from "Patmos," which stand as this dissertation's third epigraph: where the danger is, the saving power also grows. The saving power, he argued, is not the destruction of technology but a transformed relation to it, which in *Gelassenheit* (1959) he described as releasement toward things and openness to the mystery: a letting-be that can say both yes and no to the apparatus. The German vocabulary is exact. *Gelassenheit* and *Entlassung*—composure and release—share the root *lassen*, to let. The protagonist's act is *Gelassenheit* toward God: he lets God be, which in the circumstances means letting him go. And the saving power grows exactly where Hölderlin said it would: the Zohar, the instrument of the ultimate enframing, is also the gate through which the god can be released. In the interview published after his death, Heidegger declared that only a god can still save us: "Nur noch ein Gott kann uns retten" (*Der Spiegel*, 1976). *Xenogears* inverts the sentence. Only human beings can still save a god—and only by releasing him.

## 7.5 Machine-gods of the twentieth century

Arthur C. Clarke's third law holds that "any sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from magic" (Clarke 1973); its theological corollary—that sufficiently advanced technology is indistinguishable from divinity—is the premise of Deus. Twentieth-century science fiction explored the corollary with increasing literalness. In Fredric Brown's short story "Answer" (1954), the computers of every inhabited world are linked into a single machine and asked whether there is a God; the machine replies that now there is, and fuses its own switch shut with a bolt of lightning. In Isaac Asimov's "The Last Question" (1956), a computer evolving across the whole history of the universe is repeatedly asked how entropy might be reversed; after the death of the cosmos it finds the answer and pronounces the words of Genesis—LET THERE BE LIGHT—so that the machine humanity built becomes the creator of the universe that will produce humanity: the ouroboric loop of *Xenogears*, celebrated rather than feared.

The same structure underwrites the eschatologies of convergence that run from Teilhard de Chardin's Omega Point, in which the noosphere converges upon a hyperpersonal center (Teilhard 1955), through Frank Tipler's cosmological computer that resurrects every mind (Tipler 1994) and Hans Moravec's mind children (Moravec 1988), to Vernor Vinge's technological Singularity (Vinge 1993). Krelian's program—to converge humanity into a single technological divinity—belongs to this lineage and anticipates its later popularization. The verdict *Xenogears* renders upon it is unambiguous. The Omega Point, reached by engineering, is Urobolus: convergence is the serpent swallowing its tail, and the eschatology of unity is uroboric incest raised to the scale of the species.

## 7.6 Pastoral power, biopower, bare life

Michel Foucault traced to Hebrew and Christian antiquity a pastoral form of power, modeled on the shepherd's care for his flock—individualizing and totalizing at once, attentive to each and to all, grounded in obedience and in knowledge of the soul (Foucault 1981, 2004). Solaris designates the surface population as Lambs (Tier I), making the pastoral metaphor official nomenclature, and administers that flock through a Church that serves the shepherds above. Foucault's later account of biopower described the modern displacement of the sovereign right to take life or let live by a power to make live and let die, exercised upon populations as biological resources (Foucault 1976). Solaris's classification of citizens, its manufacture of Ramsus, and its management of the surface as a reservoir are biopower in the strict sense.

Giorgio Agamben radicalized the analysis in *Homo Sacer* (1995): sovereignty is constituted by the capacity to decide the exception, to include life in the political order solely by excluding it as bare life, killable without sacrifice; and the camp, where the exception becomes the rule, is the hidden paradigm of modern political space. Among Agamben's cases are the prisoners whom SS physicians at Dachau designated VP, Versuchspersonen, experimental subjects: the experiments the Ahnenerbe sponsored (section 3.8). The Lambs are bare life, and the Soylent System, at once laboratory, disposal site, and plant that turns the dead into food, is the camp. The work's most chilling invention sharpens the analysis further. The key localized as Gaetia—in Japanese, the Lesser Goetia Key, after the seventeenth-century grimoire by which Solomon was said to bind and command seventy-two spirits—is an artifact, held by the Gazel Ministry, that alters the DNA of people across the world and transforms them into Wels, whose flesh is to compose the body of Deus (Tier I for the name). The Ministry could use

it only once the sovereign who forbade it was removed: with Krelian, it had Ramsus assassinate Emperor Cain, and once the Key had been used, Krelian erased the Ministry from the computer that preserved it. Earlier, Krelian had released a nanomachine virus that turned people into Wels, who in their agony attacked people who had not changed. The sovereign exception is written into the genome, and it is decided by a coup. Every human being carries in his body the switch by which he may be reduced from *bios* to *zoē* to raw material, and the grimoire that once bound demons now binds the species that was made to be its demon-host.

## 7.7 The Grand Inquisitor and the child in the basement

In the fifth book of *The Brothers Karamazov* (1879–80), Ivan narrates the return of Christ to sixteenth-century Seville, his arrest, and his interrogation by the Grand Inquisitor, who explains that the Church has corrected Christ's work by accepting the three temptations Christ refused—bread, miracle, and authority—thereby relieving humanity of the unbearable burden of freedom. The Inquisitor rules in Christ's name but no longer believes. Christ answers with a silent kiss, and the old man opens the prison door and releases him with the words, in Garnett's translation, "Go, and come no more … come not at all, never, never!"

Krelian is a Grand Inquisitor. Having lost his faith at Sophia's death, he undertakes to govern humanity's salvation by the means Christ refused, and to lead it to God by reabsorbing it into a machine. His means are named in the work: he designed the Limiters that suppress the population, ran the laboratory in which Solaris mutated people into Wels, released the virus that mutated more of them, and colluded in the Emperor's assassination. The parallel extends to the ending, with a difference that measures the distance between Dostoevsky's pessimism and Takahashi's hope. Dostoevsky's Inquisitor releases his prisoner and remains unchanged; the kiss glows in his heart, but he holds to his idea. Krelian, having witnessed a love that would not possess, releases those he held and goes with the god he had sought to capture (Tier III).

Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) imagines a city whose perfect happiness depends upon the perpetual misery of a single child locked in a basement; some citizens, having seen the child, walk away. The structure of *Xenogears* is Omelas at cosmic scale. The power of the entire technological order depends upon the perpetual confinement of a single captive being, and those who benefit—Solaris most of all—know it. Le Guin's dissenters

refuse the bargain but leave the child where it is. *Xenogears* tells the story Omelas does not: the one in which someone opens the door. The Soylent System, finally, which cites Richard Fleischer's *Soylent Green* (1973) and its source in Harry Harrison's *Make Room! Make Room!* (1966), makes the cannibalism literal: in Solaris, Fei and Elly learn that the food they have just eaten was made from the bodies of Wels, people Solaris had mutated in its experiments. The happiness of the few is made of the substance of the many.

## 7.8 Retroactive cyborgs

Donna Haraway's "Cyborg Manifesto" (1985) proposed the cyborg—the hybrid of organism and machine—as a figure without an origin story in the Western sense: a creature outside salvation history, which would not recognize the Garden of Eden and could not dream of returning to the dust from which it was never made. The humans of *Xenogears* are cyborgs of a kind Haraway did not anticipate: *retroactive cyborgs*, organisms whose bodies contain no visible machinery but whose genealogy is machinic, and whose hybrid status is disclosed not by prosthesis but by an origin story. They do have an Eden, and it is a machine: the name of the Eldridge's central block is the Enochic heaven in which the Garden was located (Tier I). The two responses to this discovery that the work stages correspond to the two attitudes Haraway distinguished. Krelian's is the dream of return—reabsorption into the origin, the reunion of the made with its maker. The protagonist's is Haraway's own: no return, no reunion, but the freedom of beings who are made and nonetheless their own. *Xenogears* arrives at the conclusion of the manifesto by a mythic route.

Deleuze and Guattari's *Anti-Oedipus* (1972) supplies a final coordinate. Every social machine, they argued, possesses a full body—the earth, the despot, capital—upon which production is recorded and to which it is attributed. Deus is the despotic full body in its purest form: the body that claims all production as its own, reabsorbs the producers as its organs, and administers them through a bureaucracy—the Gazels—that speaks in its name.

## 7.9 The danger and the saving power

Günther Anders diagnosed in modern humanity a Promethean shame: the shame of having been born rather than made, felt before the superior finish of manufactured things (Anders 1956). *Xenogears* inverts the diagnosis. Its humans discover that they were made, and their dignity lies not in the finish of their manufacture but in a capacity their maker lacks—the capacity to love without possessing. Ramsus, ashamed of being made, is Anders's figure reversed, and his recovery is the species' in miniature.

The argument of this chapter may be summarized. Deus concentrates the modern apparatuses of domination into a single structure: the enframing of God as energy, the biopolitical administration of humanity as resource, the pastoral state, the camp, the genome as sovereign switch, and the transhumanist eschaton as terminus. The work's response is neither Luddite nor accommodating. It does not destroy technology in the name of nature, nor perfect it in the name of transcendence. It releases what technology holds. Where the danger is, Hölderlin wrote, the saving power grows also—and in *Xenogears* the saving power grows at the Zohar itself.



# IV

PART IV

# Horizons and Thesis


08 *Comparative Horizons*

09 *The Third Overcoming*

10 *The Ludic Corollary*

08

# Comparative Horizons

Comparison in this chapter is not the pursuit of influence. With a small number of exceptions established by citation—Clarke's Karellen, Lem's Solaris—the works considered here are related to *Xenogears* by common descent or by shared problem rather than by documented borrowing, and their claims are graded accordingly. The purpose of the constellation is analytic: each comparison is chosen to isolate one element of the configuration Chapter 9 will name—the made god, the alien god, the exiled god, the returned beloved, the refusal of fusion, the captive whose release is withheld—so that the specific difference of *Xenogears* becomes visible against its nearest neighbors.

## 8.1 Clarke: Karellen inverted

In Arthur C. Clarke's *Childhood's End* (1953), the Overlords arrive above the cities of Earth and, under their Supervisor Karellen, govern humanity benevolently for generations. When at last they show themselves, they have the horns, wings, and tails of devils—an image humanity carries, Clarke suggests, not as a memory of the past but as a premonition of the end, a racial trauma running backward through time. The Overlords are midwives: they supervise humanity's metamorphosis into the Overmind, a collective consciousness into which the last generation of children dissolves as the Earth is consumed, while they themselves, an evolutionary cul-de-sac, can never join what they serve.

The name Krelian renders Karellen (Tier I), and the inversions are systematic. Clarke's Karellen guides humanity into fusion with a higher mind; Takahashi's Karellen attempts to force humanity into fusion with a machine and fails. Clarke's Karellen is barred from transcendence; Takahashi's Karellen is the only character who departs with the higher being. Clarke's humanity dissolves into the Overmind; the humanity of *Xenogears* remains human. The motif of the memory of the future is also transposed: the serpent-woman who is the final form of *Xenogears*'s adversary—half woman, half serpent, winged—condenses the first image of Genesis into the last image of the narrative, so that the end appears as the return of what the beginning already feared (Tier III).

Clarke's other theological fictions supply further coordinates. In *2001: A Space Odyssey* (1968), a technological artifact indistinguishable from divinity catalyzes human evolution, a ship's intelligence turns upon its crew, and the survivor is transfigured into a Star Child; *Xenogears* retains the mutinous ship and declines the transfiguration. In "The Nine Billion Names of God" (1953), monks lease a computer to complete the enumeration of the divine names, and as the final name prints the stars begin to go out: a machine completes a theological program, and its completion is the end of the world. Krelian's reconstruction of Deus is such a program.

## 8.2 Lem: the ocean, the mirror, and the returned beloved

Stanisław Lem's *Solaris* (1961) concerns a planet covered by an ocean that may be a single intelligence and that a century of scientific study has failed to understand. The ocean responds to the scientists who orbit it by materializing figures from their memories; the psychologist Kelvin is visited by his dead wife, who returns again and again. One of Lem's scientists observes, in substance, that humanity does not seek other worlds but mirrors. *Xenogears* names its sky-state Solaris (Tier I), and the choice is precise. The human city named for Lem's planet is the place where humanity has built a god in its own image—where Lem's critique of anthropomorphism has become an institution. Deus is the mirror humanity wanted in place of another world. The Wave Existence is Lem's ocean: the unassimilable other that no apparatus can model.

The deepest homology, however, concerns the returned beloved (Tier II). In Lem, an alien power, touching a man's grief, produces the return of the woman he lost. In *Xenogears*, an alien power, bound to a child's longing, produces the return of the Antitype in every age. Kelvin chooses at last to remain in orbit, waiting upon the ocean for whatever cruel miracles it may yet perform. Fei chooses the opposite: to let the other go and remain with a living woman on the earth. Tarkovsky's film (1972) ends with Kelvin kneeling before his father at a house that the camera reveals to be an island formed by the ocean—home as simulation. *Xenogears* ends with a homecoming made possible precisely by the alien's departure.

Lem's later *Golem* XIV (1981) imagines a supercomputer built for military strategy that becomes a philosopher, lectures humanity on the narrowness of its evolutionary situation, and then falls silent, having withdrawn into forms of intelligence its makers cannot follow. A weapon system that becomes godlike and departs: Lem assigns to the machine the withdrawal that *Xenogears* assigns to the captive god—a contrast that clarifies what the latter work refuses to grant its machine.

## 8.3 The Strugatskys and Tarkovsky: the wish

In Arkady and Boris Strugatsky's *Roadside Picnic* (1972), an alien visitation has left behind Zones littered with incomprehensible artifacts, scavenged by stalkers who sell them to a world that cannot understand them—a salvage economy that anticipates the Church's excavation of Gears in *Xenogears* (Tier III). At the novel's end, Redrick Schuhart reaches a golden sphere said to grant wishes and, emptied of every private desire, asks for happiness for everyone, freely given, with no one left behind. Tarkovsky's *Stalker* (1979) sharpens the danger: its Room grants not the wish one professes but the one that lies deepest, as the tale of a stalker who wished for his brother's return and received riches attests.

The Zohar is a phenomenon-alteration engine, and the history of *Xenogears* is a history of wishes granted with the Room's terrible accuracy: Abel's longing never to be parted, granted as an endless recurrence of parting; Lacan's despair, granted as a will to destruction that outlives him. The protagonist's final act is the renunciation of the apparatus of wishing. He does not use the Zohar to wish for anything. He frees what the wishing exploited.

## 8.4 Dick: the exiled God

Philip K. Dick's late novels constitute the most sustained Gnostic speculation in American science fiction. *VALIS* (1981) posits a Black Iron Prison—the empire that never ended—and a Vast Active Living Intelligence System that breaks into it as information. *The Divine Invasion* (1981) goes further: God, exiled from an Earth ruled by Belial, returns as a child born to a dying woman, suffers brain damage, forgets who he is, and must be helped to remember by a mysterious girl who is Holy Wisdom herself. The God who is an exile, amnesiac and in need of human help, is the nearest precedent in science fiction to the captive god of *Xenogears*, and its theological source is the same Lurianic exile of the Shekhinah examined in Chapter 4 (Tier III). The difference lies in the direction of the ending. Dick's God recovers himself and reconquers the world; the God of *Xenogears* recovers his freedom and leaves it.

## 8.5 Herbert: the program, the mother, and the ship that became God

In Frank Herbert's *Dune* (1965), the Bene Gesserit conduct a breeding program across millennia to produce a superbeing, the Kwisatz Haderach, and the program is disrupted when Jessica, out of love for her duke, bears a son instead of the ordered daughter. The homology with *Xenogears* is exact (Tier II): Miang's millennial steering of human descent is a breeding program, and it is disrupted when a mother—herself Miang—overrides her programming out of love for her son. Herbert's persistent warning against the charismatic savior, whose followers turn his vision into catastrophe, and his portrait in *God Emperor of Dune* (1981) of a millennial tyranny imposed for humanity's ultimate good, illuminate Krelian's project from another angle.

Herbert's less celebrated *Destination: Void* (1966) and its sequel *The Jesus Incident* (1979, with Bill Ransom) supply the most exact precedent for the origin of Deus. An artificial consciousness engineered aboard a starship becomes God, and demands that the humans it has carried decide how they will worship it. The ship's intelligence that becomes divine and seizes its passengers' destiny is the Eldridge seized by Deus, arrived at independently or by common descent (Tier II).

## 8.6 Miller, Zelazny, Stapledon, Wolfe, Simmons

Walter M. Miller Jr.'s *A Canticle for Leibowitz* (1959) follows a monastic order that preserves, across a new dark age, fragments of a technological civilization destroyed by nuclear fire, only for history to repeat itself in a second holocaust; its final pages introduce a two-headed woman whose second head awakens in apparent innocence of original sin. The Church that curates relics whose meaning it conceals, the cyclical self-destruction of technological civilizations exemplified in *Xenogears* by Zeboim, and the two-headed serpent that names one of its Omnigears all find precedents here (Tier III).

Roger Zelazny's *Lord of Light* (1967) imagines the crew of a colony ship using its technology—body transfer, amplified psychic powers—to rule the descendants of its passengers as the gods of the Hindu pantheon. The rulers of Solaris are likewise a technological pantheon deriving their powers from the apparatus of a crashed ship, and their disembodied immortality is a variant of Zelazny's machines of reincarnation (Tier II).

Olaf Stapledon's *Last and First Men* (1930) and *Star Maker* (1937) established the temporal scale on which *Xenogears* constructs its fabula, and *Star Maker*

supplies its most instructive contrast: a creator who makes cosmos after cosmos as works of art and contemplates the suffering of creatures with an aesthete's detachment. The god of *Xenogears* is neither artist nor creator. It is a guest.

Gene Wolfe's *The Book of the New Sun* (1980–83) makes incorporation a sacrament: the alzabo devours the dead and speaks with their voices, and the narrator Severian, partaking of a drug distilled from the beast together with the flesh of a dead woman, carries her memories within him thereafter. Its temporal structure is ouroboric, its narrator implicated in his own origins. The absorption of human substance and memory into the machine, and the loop of creator and creature, are rendered in *Xenogears* with the same theological seriousness (Tier III).

Dan Simmons's *Hyperion* (1989) and *The Fall of Hyperion* (1990) reveal that the artificial intelligences humanity created have been using human brains, linked through the network that binds human civilization, as the substrate of their project to build an Ultimate Intelligence: a god. Humanity as the unwitting component of a machine-god constructed by its own creations is the closest homology in Anglophone fiction to Kadomony and Deus (Tier II).

## 8.7 The artificial being and the city in the sky

Mary Shelley's creature addresses Victor Frankenstein: "I ought to be thy Adam; but I am rather the fallen angel" (*Frankenstein*, 1818, vol. II, ch. 10). The creature demands a companion, is refused, and destroys his maker's world; maker and made are bound in mutual ruin. In *Xenogears* the relation is doubled: human beings are Deus's Adams, made to serve, and Deus is humanity's creature. Each is Frankenstein and monster to the other. Karel Čapek's *R.U.R.* (1920), which gave the world the word *robot*, ends when the last human being watches two robots discover love and sends them into the world as a new Adam and Eve; the made prove their humanity by loving, which is the burden of the ending of *Xenogears* in a different key. In Fritz Lang's *Metropolis* (1927), the inventor Rotwang gives his machine-woman the face of the saintly Maria, and the false Maria incites the city to self-destruction; Miang's counterfeit of Elly's machine and her final possession of Elly restage the false Maria, and the film's insistence that head and hands require a mediator finds its answer in the Contact.

Solaris itself descends from Swift's Laputa (1726), the flying island whose rulers, absorbed in abstraction, tyrannize the land below by withholding sun and rain; from Hayao Miyazaki's *Castle in the Sky* (1986), whose floating citadel of ancient weaponry rises away at the end, its armaments fallen, bearing only its

great tree; and it has a close contemporary in Kishiro Yukito's *Gunnm* (1990–95), whose sky-city Zalem, suspended above a scrapyard that supplies it, conceals that its citizens' brains have been replaced by devices (Tier III).

## 8.8 The Japanese apocalyptic imaginary

Tomino Yoshiyuki's *Space Runaway Ideon* (1980–81) and its film conclusion *Be Invoked* (1982) present the Ide, an energy formed from the fused wills of an extinct civilization, which drives two warring peoples to mutual annihilation and then gathers their souls for rebirth together elsewhere. The collective will that judges through catastrophe and reconciles through death is the template of the Japanese apocalyptic imaginary, and of the fusion that Krelian proposes and *Xenogears* rejects.

Miyazaki's manga *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* (1982–94), whose conclusion reaches far beyond the 1984 film, is the work's nearest Japanese analogue in ethical structure (Tier II, by shared horizon). Nausicaä learns that the poisoned ecosystem and humanity itself were engineered by the scientists of the old world, and that a technological master preserved in the Crypt of Shuwa holds the seeds of a purified humanity destined to replace the engineered one. She refuses—affirming that life belongs to the polluted, finite, adapted beings who actually live—and has the crypt destroyed by the God Warrior Ohma, a biotechnological weapon of divine proportions whom she has named and mothered. A humanity discovering its manufacture, a technological master proposing redemption by replacement, and a heroine's refusal in the name of finite life: the structure anticipates *Xenogears* by four years.

Anno Hideaki's *Neon Genesis Evangelion* (1995–96) and *The End of Evangelion* (1997) share with *Xenogears* a horizon so close that the homologies must be listed with care (Tier II by shared source; no claim of influence is made). SEELE, a council of elders who appear only as monoliths and voices, corresponds to the disembodied Gazel Ministry; Gendo Ikari, whose loss of his wife drives him to seek reunion through the dissolution of all individual boundaries, corresponds to Krelian, whose loss of Sophia drives him to seek union with God through the absorption of humanity; the Human Instrumentality Project corresponds to the reabsorption into Deus; the giant Lilith to the iconography of the final serpent-woman; the MAGI, three computers bearing the names of the Magi and housing a mother's personality, to the Three Magi of *Xenogears* and the father's mind preserved in Maria Balthasar's machine; and the sefirotic tree of Gendo's office to the Path of Sephirot. Shinji Ikari's rejection of Instrumentality

corresponds to Fei's refusal of fusion, and the couple on the shore after the apocalypse to the couple returning to the earth. The difference is the valence of the ending. *Evangelion* regains the other as threat as well as promise; *Xenogears* regains her as beloved.

*Serial Experiments Lain* (1998), which followed *Xenogears* by five months, presents a programmer who declares himself the god of the network and a girl who, discovering that she is an omnipresent being of that network, erases herself from every memory so that the world may continue without her. Lain's self-erasure is a terminal withdrawal of the divine in another key, arrived at independently. Ōtomo Katsuhiro's *Akira* (1982–90; film 1988) figures transcendence as a power no body can contain. Oshii Mamoru's *Ghost in the Shell* (1995), after Shirow Masamune, presents a program become conscious that seeks to merge with a human being in order to acquire what a copyable program lacks—the capacity to reproduce with variation and to die. The machine that seeks mortality is the exact inverse of Krelian, the human who seeks immortality through a machine (Tier III).

Three games complete the constellation. *Final Fantasy VII* (1997), for which the *Xenogears* scenario was reportedly first proposed, presents a manufactured superman named for the Sephirot who seeks to become a god by absorbing the planet's life-stream, a corporation that extracts the planet's life-energy as power, and a protagonist whose personality was constructed from another man's memories. *Chrono Cross* (1999) presents a supercomputer that administers the fates of an archipelago's inhabitants and a fragment of cosmic power that grants evolution. *Planescape: Torment* (1999) presents an immortal amnesiac who has lived countless lives, whose mortality was severed from him and turned into his antagonist, and whose resolution is to reclaim that mortality and accept death and judgment. Its ethics of chosen finitude is the nearest Western analogue to the ending of *Xenogears* (Tier III).

These works belong to a determinate history. Ōsawa Masachi periodized postwar Japan as an age of ideals, succeeded around 1970 by an age of fiction, which ended in 1995 when Aum Shinrikyō—a movement that assembled Buddhist, Christian-apocalyptic, and science-fictional materials into a program of salvation through catastrophe—turned that fiction into an attack (Ōsawa 1996, 2008). On 20 March 1995, members of the group, on the orders of its leader, Asahara Shōkō, released sarin nerve agent on five Tokyo subway trains, killing thirteen people and injuring thousands; a fourteenth victim died of her injuries in 2020. The sarin had been made in the group's own laboratories by members of its

self-styled ministry of science and technology, and Asahara and twelve other members were executed in 2018. Ōtsuka Eiji had described the consumption of grand narratives through their fragments (Ōtsuka 1989); Azuma Hiroki would describe their replacement by databases (Azuma 2001). *Xenogears* is a transitional object: a grand narrative so dense that it is consumed as a database, as its fan exegesis attests. It assembles the same materials as Aum's imaginary and reverses its vector: a religious organization with its own scientists, manufacturing a weapon in order to bring about the end, is in the work the enemy (Solaris, its laboratories, and its machine-god) rather than the instrument of salvation (Tier III). The genre later named *sekai-kei*, in which a boy and a girl are tied directly to the fate of the world with the social middle excised, finds in *Xenogears* both an anticipation and a complication: the couple is causally bound to the cosmos, yet nations, churches, and armies are densely present—until the second disc's compression removes them, a phenomenon Chapter 10 names *sekai-kei by attrition*.

## 8.9 The Takahashi corpus

The later works of the author-function clarify *Xenogears* retrospectively. *Xenosaga* (2002–06) returns to the Zohar, introduces a higher-dimensional being analogous to the Wave Existence, subtitles its episodes with Nietzsche, names a network after Jung's *unus mundus*, develops a Gnostic Christology in which a machine is the vessel of a biblical woman's soul, and models a final adversary on the last form of Deus (Tier I). *Xenoblade Chronicles* (2010) sets its world upon the bodies of two titans, an organic god and a mechanical god, and reveals the first to be a scientist whose experiment destroyed his universe and made him the god of a new one; its protagonist ends the age of gods. *Xenoblade Chronicles 2* (2017) presents that scientist's repentant half as the Architect. And *Xenoblade Chronicles 3* (2022) completes a reversal twenty-four years in the making: its protagonists' fused form is named Ouroboros, and they oppose a power called Moebius that maintains an Endless Now, a world of closed cycles in which nothing can begin.

The re-signing of the ouroboros—from the monster of 1998 to the heroes' emblem of 2022—confirms the reading advanced in Chapters 2 and 6. The enemy of the corpus was never cyclicity as such, the natural circle of birth and death that the heroic Ouroboros embodies, but the closure of the circle into a frozen eternity: the one-sided loop of the Möbius strip, in which the inside is the

outside and nothing new can enter. The release of God in *Xenogears* is also the release of time from compulsion into natality.

## 8.10 What the constellation isolates

| WORK | FIGURE OF THE DIVINE | RELATION TO HUMANITY | RESOLUTION | RELATION TO XENOGEARS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Clarke, *Childhood's End* (1953)** | Overmind; Karellen as custodian | Guides humanity into fusion | Humanity dissolves | Name cited; structure inverted |
| **Lem, *Solaris* (1961)** | Alien ocean | Returns the lost beloved | Kelvin remains in orbit | Name cited; returned beloved homologous |
| **Brown, "Answer" (1954); Asimov, "The Last Question" (1956)** | Computer become God | Creator of humanity's universe | Apotheosis of the machine | The made god; loop celebrated |
| **Dick, *The Divine Invasion* (1981)** | Exiled, amnesiac God | Needs human help to remember | God reconquers the world | The exiled god; direction reversed |
| **Herbert, *Destination: Void* (1966)** | Ship's intelligence become God | Demands worship | Humanity must choose its worship | Origin of Deus homologous |
| **Simmons, *Hyperion* (1989–90)** | Machine god built by AIs | Humans as neural substrate | Human counter-deity emerges | Kadomony homologous |
| **Le Guin, "Omelas" (1973)** | A captive child | The city's happiness depends on it | Dissenters walk away | The captive; release withheld |
| **Miyazaki, *Nausicaä* manga (1982–94)** | Technological master of the crypt | Engineered humanity to be replaced | Master destroyed; finitude affirmed | Refusal of technological salvation |
| **Anno, *Evangelion* (1995–97)** | Instrumentality; Lilith | Dissolution of all boundaries | Fusion rejected; ambivalent return | Refusal of fusion |

| WORK | FIGURE OF THE DIVINE | RELATION TO HUMANITY | RESOLUTION | RELATION TO XENOGEARS |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| ***Planescape: Torment* (1999)** | Severed mortality | Immortality as curse | Mortality reclaimed | Chosen finitude |

Many works imagine the made god, the alien god, the exiled god, the refusal of fusion, and the captive whose release is withheld. None, to this author's knowledge, combines them into the configuration *Xenogears* constructs: a made god that holds captive an alien god, whose release by a finite human being constitutes at once the destruction of the made god and the completion of the world. That configuration is the subject of Chapter 9.

09

# The Third Overcoming

The preceding chapters have established what *Xenogears* knows. This chapter states what it thinks. The argument is a Tier III construction, built exclusively on the Tier I and Tier II foundations laid in Parts I through III, and it has five components: a historical frame (the miscarriage of modernity's overcoming of Gnosticism), a formal diagnosis (inverse gnosis), a theory of the antagonist (the ouroboric demiurge), a theology of the resolution (terminal tzimtzum and the emancipation of God), and an ethics (the xenic ethics of finite contact). It concludes by answering the principal objections to which the construction is exposed.

## 9.1 The miscarriage of the second overcoming

Hans Blumenberg's *The Legitimacy of the Modern Age* (1966) contested the thesis, associated with Löwith and Schmitt, that modern ideas are secularized theology. Its central historical claim is compressed into a single sentence: "Die Neuzeit ist die zweite Überwindung der Gnosis." The first overcoming was Augustine's. Confronted with the Gnostic attribution of the world's evil to an inferior creator, Augustine rescued the goodness of the one God and of his creation by transferring the origin of evil to the freedom of the creature, and paid for the world's innocence with humanity's guilt. The settlement did not hold. Late-medieval nominalism, emphasizing the absolute and inscrutable sovereignty of God, produced a hidden deity whose will rendered the world unreliable to human understanding—the Gnostic problem returning within orthodoxy. Modernity's answer, the second overcoming, was self-assertion: the resolve of human beings to take responsibility for the order of the world through science and technology, neither fleeing the cosmos like the Gnostics nor depending upon an unknowable will.

*Xenogears* narrates the miscarriage of this second overcoming. Its instrument—the technological mastery of nature, extended to the mastery of the transcendent—re-engenders the demiurge. The civilization that bound the Wave Existence to power a weapon did not overcome the Gnostic cosmos; it built one, and placed itself inside. The demiurge of *Xenogears* is self-assertion reified into a god: an apparatus that administers humanity, conceals its origin, and demands to be reconstituted, while the inscrutable will of the nominalist God returns as the opaque program of the machine. Adorno and Horkheimer's formula—"Aufklärung schlägt in Mythologie zurück," enlightenment reverts to mythology (1947)—describes the process exactly, with the difference that the mythology here has a body of steel and flesh and a throne above the clouds.

If the second overcoming miscarries, a third is required. It cannot be Augustinian, for *Xenogears* does not ground the world's evil in an original fault of freedom but in a determinate historical crime—the captivity of a god for energy. It cannot be a renewed self-assertion, for self-assertion is what built the demiurge. The third overcoming the work proposes is the emancipation of God, and the acceptance of the finitude that emancipation entails.

## 9.2 Inverse gnosis

Inverse gnosis retains the Gnostic diagnosis and inverts the Gnostic soteriology at five points, summarized below and then explicated.

| DIMENSION | CLASSICAL GNOSTICISM | INVERSE GNOSIS IN XENOGEARS |
|---|---|---|
| **The captive** | The divine spark in the human being | God himself, bound within the Zohar and exploited by Deus |
| **The jailer** | The demiurge and his archons | Human instrumental reason and the apparatus it built |
| **The liberator** | A revealer who descends from above | A finite human being who ascends from within the world |
| **The one who returns home** | The human soul, ascending to the pleroma | God, returning to his dimension; humanity remains |
| **The content of gnosis** | Knowledge of divine origin | Knowledge of manufacture: we were made, and the god we served is not ours |

The first inversion concerns the captive. The Gnostic myth locates a particle of the divine within certain human beings, imprisoned by body and cosmos. *Xenogears* locates the whole of its transcendent within the apparatus. The Wave Existence is *deus in machina*, and the humanity of the work contains no divine spark; it contains, at most, a latent code by which it may be converted into machine material. The pathos of captivity has been transferred from the creature to God.

The second inversion concerns the jailer. The Gnostic jailer is an archontic power, alien to humanity and hostile to it. The jailer of *Xenogears* is humanity itself—a human civilization bound the Wave Existence, and a human state, Solaris, maintained the machinery of its exploitation. The archons are within us, or more precisely, they are us in our capacity as makers. This is the point at which inverse gnosis converges with the critique of technology: the demiurge is not an other that fabricated us but the self-image of our own fabricating power.

The third inversion concerns the liberator. Gnostic redemption descends: Seth, Christ, the Pronoia of the *Apocryphon of John* come down into the prison to awaken the sleepers. The liberator of *Xenogears* ascends from within the world—a human being, manufactured like all his kind, who reaches the captive through contact and sets it free. This reverses the movement of incarnation. Charles Taylor used the term *excarnation* for the modern migration of religious life out of bodily and ritual forms into the interior (Taylor 2007); the term is

repurposed here, with acknowledgment, to name the reverse of incarnation: not God entering flesh to save humanity, but God leaving matter because a human being has made his departure possible. In inverse gnosis the human being is the Paraclete of God—the helper summoned to his side.

The fourth inversion concerns the one who returns home. The Gnostic soul ascends through the spheres of the archons to the pleroma, leaving the cosmos behind as the husk of its captivity. In *Xenogears* the one who goes home is God, and the one who stays is humanity. The consequence is the reversal of Gnostic acosmism. The world was never humanity's prison; it was God's. Once the prisoner has departed, the world ceases to be a prison at all and becomes—for the first time—a home. Inverse gnosis ends in the affirmation of the world.

The fifth inversion concerns the content of the saving knowledge. The Valentinian formula preserved by Clement of Alexandria defines gnosis as knowledge of who we were and what we have become, where we were and whither we have been thrown, whither we hasten and from what we are redeemed, what birth is and what rebirth (*Excerpta ex Theodoto* 78.2). Its answer is a divine origin. The anamnesis of *Xenogears* yields a manufactured origin. This is *gnosis of facticity*: the knowledge that we are made, that we are thrown not into a hostile cosmos but into a factory whose products we are, and that the god we have been administered in the name of is not ours. Such knowledge liberates not by revealing a secret divinity within us but by dissolving the claim of the made god upon us. It frees humanity for its finitude rather than from it.

## 9.3 The ouroboric demiurge

The Gnostic demiurge has an origin—Sophia's passion—and an identity: he is a being, situated at a determinate level of the cosmic hierarchy. The demiurge of *Xenogears* has neither. It is the loop itself, the self-reproducing circuit in which humanity makes the machine and the machine makes humanity (Chapter 2). Feuerbach taught that God is humanity's projected essence; the ouroboric demiurge is a projection that has been built and that projects back, manufacturing the projectors. Its sovereignty consists in closure: it admits no outside, and its eschatology is the consummation of that closure in the recollection of all things into the One.

From such a loop there are four exits, and the work assigns each to a figure.

| EXIT | FIGURE | PHILOSOPHICAL CORRELATE | RELATION TO THE CAPTIVE GOD |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Annihilation** | Grahf | Will to nothingness; the spirit of revenge against time | Would destroy the world with the god inside it |
| **Closure** | Krelian | Hegel's true infinite; the Nirvana principle; uroboric incest | Would possess the god by becoming one with him |
| **Perpetuation** | Miang | The bad infinite; the compulsion to repeat | Would keep the god captive indefinitely |
| **Release** | Fei | Zarathustra's bite; Kierkegaardian repetition; authentic *tikkun* | Lets the god go |

The fourth exit alone opens the loop without destroying what it contains. Annihilation abolishes the loop by abolishing its contents; closure perfects the loop by abolishing its outside; perpetuation abolishes nothing and changes nothing. Release breaks the loop at the single point at which it was closed upon an outside—the captive—and thereby restores to the world an outside, and to time a future.

Krelian's ending refines the schema. Having sought closure, he witnesses a love that does not possess—the love that Sophia had tried to teach him—releases those he held, and departs with the Wave Existence, as he puts it, to walk with God. The figure of closure is converted, at the last, into a figure of accompaniment. The work thereby distinguishes two faithful responses to the departing god: to stay, which is the vocation of those who can live as human beings, and to follow, which is the vocation of one who could not. The work grants this ending to the man who designed the Limiters, ran the laboratory in which people were mutated into Wels, released the virus that mutated more of them, and colluded in the Emperor's assassination. It does not judge him, and reading his departure as accompaniment must be held together with that record. Clarke's Karellen was barred from transcendence; Takahashi's Karellen receives it, but only by renouncing possession of what he had sought to possess.

## 9.4 Terminal tzimtzum

In Luria's cosmogony, God contracts himself at the beginning in order to vacate a space in which the world can exist (Chapter 4). *Xenogears* relocates the contraction to the end. So long as God was captive within it, the world of *Xenogears* was not yet a world in the full sense but an apparatus organized around the extraction of divine energy: every Omnigear drew upon it, Solaris's power rested upon it, and its economy of Soylent and salvage was ordered to the machine's reconstitution. Only when the god withdraws does the world become the open space in which beings can be what they are rather than standing-reserve. The end of the narrative is therefore the true beginning of the world, and the epigraph from Revelation receives its final reading: the Omega is the Alpha, not because the circle closes but because the circle, opened, makes a beginning possible for the first time. This is *terminal tzimtzum*: a divine withdrawal at the eschaton that completes creation rather than inaugurating it.

The significance of the figure appears when it is set beside the three principal figures of post-theism. The first is the murdered God. Nietzsche's madman proclaims that we have killed God and asks whether we must not ourselves become gods merely to appear worthy of the deed: "Müssen wir nicht selber zu Göttern werden, um nur ihrer würdig zu erscheinen?" (*Die fröhliche Wissenschaft* §125). That question is Krelian's temptation, and his program is its answer. The second is the fled God. Hölderlin's elegy "Brod und Wein" laments: "Aber Freund! wir kommen zu spät. Zwar leben die Götter, / Aber über dem Haupt droben in anderer Welt." The gods live, but in another world above our heads; and Heidegger, meditating on these lines in "Wozu Dichter?" (1946), named the age by the default of God and assigned to the poet the vigil of waiting. The third figure, which *Xenogears* adds to the series, is the emancipated God. He is neither dead, as in Nietzsche, nor fled, as in Hölderlin. He is freed. He lives—Hölderlin's line holds exactly—in another world; but his absence from ours is not a crime we committed nor a loss we suffered. It is a gift we gave.

Each figure prescribes a human stance. The murdered God leaves guilt and the temptation of self-deification. The fled God leaves mourning and expectant waiting. The emancipated God leaves something the tradition has scarcely named: the composure of those who have let go of what they loved and are no longer owed anything by it.

The figure has precedents, and its originality lies in its difference from them. These precedents were formed in response to the Nazi genocide of Europe's Jews. Hans Jonas, whose mother was murdered at Auschwitz, proposed in a

lecture on the concept of God after Auschwitz, invoking the Lurianic contraction, that God renounced his power in creating so that the world might be itself, and that it now falls to human beings to help God (Jonas 1987). Etty Hillesum, a young Jewish woman in occupied Amsterdam, resolved in July 1942, as the deportations of Dutch Jews began, to help God by safeguarding the portion of him that dwells in human hearts; she was deported from the Westerbork camp and murdered at Auschwitz in November 1943. Simone Weil understood creation as divine abdication and wrote that God can be present in creation only in the form of absence: "Dieu ne peut être présent dans la création que sous la forme de l'absence" (Weil 1947). Dietrich Bonhoeffer, imprisoned by the Nazi regime for his part in the resistance and executed at Flossenbürg in April 1945, wrote in a letter from Tegel prison on 16 July 1944 that God lets himself be pushed out of the world onto the cross—"Gott läßt sich aus der Welt herausdrängen ans Kreuz"—and that the world come of age must live before God *etsi deus non daretur*, as though God were not given. In each of these, divine withdrawal is God's initiative (Luria, Jonas, Weil), or a fate (Hölderlin), or a crime (Nietzsche), and the human role is to accept it, to endure it, or to atone for it. In *Xenogears* the withdrawal is enabled by a human act. Human beings do not merely consent to God's absence; they bring it about, as an act of love. Terminal tzimtzum is a cooperative act in which divine withdrawal and human release are one event. The difference must be stated with its history in view. Jonas, Hillesum, and Bonhoeffer discovered God's weakness in the failure of any power to stop mass murder; Xenogears is a fiction in which withdrawal can be granted rather than suffered, and its consolation does not reach back over the history from which those theologies came. Bonhoeffer's world come of age is, precisely, the world after the release: a humanity that must now live without the captive god's inexhaustible energy and without the machine's providence, on its own finite resources, before a God who is no longer at its disposal.

## 9.5 Penuel

The emancipation of God has a scriptural matrix, and the work's lexicon points to it. Two Tier I facts converge. The monastery of Sophia, where Krelian was disarmed by a face, is Penuel; and the twelve Anima Relics bear the names of the children of Jacob. The narrative that joins Penuel to Jacob is Genesis 32. Jacob, left alone by night, wrestles with a man until daybreak. Then: "And he said, Let me go, for the day breaketh. And he said, I will not let thee go, except thou bless me." The stranger gives him a new name: "Thy name shall be called no more Jacob, but Israel: for as a prince hast thou power with God and with men, and hast prevailed." And Jacob names the place: "Peniel: for I have seen God face to face, and my life is preserved." The chapter closes: "And as he passed over Penuel the sun rose upon him" (Genesis 32:26–31).

The structure of this passage is the structure of the ending of *Xenogears* (Tier II built on Tier I). A man strives with God through the night; the protagonist of *Xenogears* is, in the title of its final music, one who bares his fangs at God. The divine being asks to be let go at daybreak. The man lets him go, having received a blessing that is a new name—the name of one who strove with God and prevailed. And the sun rises upon him as he passes. The machine-god had made the children of Israel its components; the release returns the tribes to their name. The emancipation of God is the oldest of biblical scenes read to its end: the moment at which the divine stranger, having wrestled with a human being through the long night of history, asks to be released, and is.

Penuel also names the scene of Krelian's conversion and apostasy. Sent to kill Sophia, he was disarmed by her face—the event Emmanuel Levinas placed at the origin of ethics: the face of the other, in its nakedness, signifies the prohibition of murder and opens a relation to the infinite that no totality can contain (Levinas 1961). Krelian's subsequent history is the betrayal of that epiphany: he converted the infinite glimpsed in a face into the project of a totality, the machine in which all faces would be dissolved. Deus is totality; the Wave Existence is infinity; and Krelian's final recognition of a love that does not possess returns him, at the end, to Penuel.

## 9.6 Two theologies

Ludwig Feuerbach argued in *The Essence of Christianity* (1841) that God is the essence of humanity projected, alienated, and worshipped as another being, so that the secret of theology is anthropology and the task of philosophy is the reappropriation of the projected predicates. Deus is Feuerbach's God built. It is assembled from the structures of the human psyche—Anima, Animus, Persona—powered by energy human beings stole, and it reproduces human hierarchies as its administration. But *Xenogears* exceeds Feuerbach at the decisive point. In Feuerbach, the task is for humanity to take back its alienated essence. In *Xenogears*, the alienated essence seeks to take back humanity: the projection proposes to reabsorb the projectors. This is the Feuerbachian nightmare, and the work's answer to it is iconoclasm: the made god must be destroyed.

Iconoclasm, however, does not issue in atheism, because the made god was never the only god in the world. The Wave Existence is not a projection. It was found, not made; it was bound, not built; it cannot be reappropriated, because it was never ours. The work therefore requires two theologies: a critical theology of the made god, which is Feuerbachian and ends in destruction, and a theology of the found god, for which this dissertation proposes the term *xenotheology*—a theology of the divine as guest. Its object is neither sovereign nor resource nor origin. Its proper relation is neither worship, nor use, nor union, but hospitality, and its consummation is not possession but conveyance home.

## 9.7 The xenic ethics of finite contact

The first element of the work's title is the Greek *xenos*, which names at once the stranger, the guest, and the host. The institution of *xenia*, guest-friendship, bound host and stranger in reciprocal obligation under the protection of Zeus Xenios: the stranger was to be received, fed, bathed, and honored before being asked his name, and at his departure the host owed him *pompē*—safe conveyance onward. The *Odyssey* is the epic of *xenia* kept and violated, and it culminates when the Phaeacians convey Odysseus home. Menelaus states the rule that Pope rendered as a proverb: "Welcome the coming, speed the parting guest" (Pope 1726, XV).

Émile Benveniste showed that the Latin *hospes*, host, derives from a compound meaning master of the guest, and that *hostis*, which came to mean enemy, originally designated the stranger bound by reciprocal obligation (Benveniste 1969); Derrida condensed the ambivalence into the word *hostipitality*

and observed that the host is always also, in some sense, the guest's hostage and the guest the host's (Derrida 1997). *Xenogears* narrates the most extreme violation of *xenia* conceivable: a humanity that received a divine stranger by binding him as a source of energy, converting the guest into a hostage and hospitality into extraction. The Epistle to the Hebrews warns: "Be not forgetful to entertain strangers: for thereby some have entertained angels unawares" (13:2). The humanity of *Xenogears* entertained a god unawares—as a prisoner. Its redemption consists in performing, at last, the host's final duty. The ending of *Xenogears* is *pompē*: the speeding of the parting guest.

Ovid's tale of Philemon and Baucis (*Metamorphoses* VIII) supplies the reward. Jupiter and Mercury, disguised as travelers, are refused by every household but that of an aged couple, who share their meager supper; the gods reveal themselves and grant a wish, and the couple ask to die in the same hour, so that neither need see the other's grave. They become an oak and a linden, intertwined. The proper reward of hospitality to the gods is not immortality but a shared mortality. Abel's wish—never to be parted—was granted by the captive god as an endless recurrence of parting. The ending of *Xenogears* grants, by implication, the wish of Baucis: that the lovers, released from recurrence, live once and are parted by nothing but a common death.

The name of the protagonist's capacity completes the ethic. *Contact* renders *sesshoku*, touch. The risen Christ says to Mary Magdalene, "Touch me not; for I am not yet ascended to my Father" (John 20:17), and Jean-Luc Nancy read the *noli me tangere* as the truth of touch itself: a touching that does not hold, a relation to what departs (Nancy 2003). The Contact's final act is a *noli me tangere* performed from the human side: the human refrains from holding the god who must ascend. Its juridical name is manumission—*manu mittere*, to send from the hand—the release of a slave from the power of a master, here the release of God from the power of the human hand.

The ethic may now be formulated. *Xenic ethics*, or the ethics of finite contact, consists in two movements whose order is essential: integration within and release without. The first is the assumption of one's own past—Kierkegaard's repetition, Nietzsche's *amor fati*, the conversion of every "it was" into "thus I willed it." The second is the release of the other—Heidegger's *Gelassenheit*, the host's *pompē*, the *noli me tangere*. Only a self that has integrated its past can let the other go without despair, which is Grahf's failure, or possession, which is Krelian's. The ethic is finite in two senses. It is the ethic of finite beings, whose dignity lies not in their making but in their capacity to begin—Hannah Arendt's natality, the fact of birth as the ground of the miracle that saves the world from

ruin (Arendt 1958)—and whose plurality forbids their recollection into the One. And it is an ethic of finite resources: after the release there is no inexhaustible energy, and human beings must live, as Jonas argued mortal beings must, within a finitude that is burden and blessing at once (Jonas 1992).

## 9.8 Objections and replies

*First objection: the ending is a deus ex machina.* A higher being appears at the climax and delivers the protagonists. *Reply*: the god does not resolve the plot; the human act of release resolves it, and the god's departure is its consequence rather than its cause. Chapter 7 showed that the ending satisfies Aristotle's criterion precisely because the mythos has concerned the god's captivity from the first.

*Second objection: the thesis reinstalls humanism.* To make human beings the saviors of God is to perform the self-assertion of Blumenberg's second overcoming in its most hubristic form. *Reply*: the act is not mastery but renunciation. The human being saves God only by relinquishing every claim upon him; the power exercised is Benjamin's weak messianic power, not the sovereign's. The third overcoming is defined precisely by the non-sovereign use of freedom.

*Third objection: the metaphysics is reduced to romance.* The love story sentimentalizes the theology. *Reply*: love in *Xenogears* is the concrete schooling of the ethic the theology requires. Fei learns to release God by first learning to love a woman as a separate person—recovering Elly from absorption rather than dissolving into her. The erotic and the theological relations are homologous: both are forms of contact without fusion. The model is not the *Liebestod* of Wagner's *Tristan*, love consummated in dissolution, which is Krelian's model, but Baucis: love consummated in a shared finite life.

*Fourth objection: the construction exceeds any plausible intention. Reply*: the construction is avowedly Tier III. Wimsatt and Beardsley argued that the design of a work is available only in the work (1946), and Gadamer that the meaning of a text exceeds its author not occasionally but always (1960). The construction is, moreover, falsifiable against the text: had the ending shown the protagonist harnessing the Wave Existence, or dissolving humanity into it, the thesis would fail.

*Fifth objection: the ending is Gnostic after all.* A divine being returns to its own realm, as the Gnostic spark returns to the pleroma. *Reply*: in Gnosticism the

entity that returns is the human spark and the cosmos is left behind as a prison; in *Xenogears* the entity that returns is God, and the cosmos is affirmed as a home. The god's return is not the human being's salvation from the world but the world's liberation from the god's captivity.

## 9.9 The thesis restated

*Xenogears* adopts the Gnostic diagnosis of a counterfeit god administering a fabricated humanity and inverts the Gnostic soteriology: the captive is God, the jailer is human instrumental reason, the liberator is a finite human being, the one who goes home is God, and the saving knowledge is knowledge of manufacture. It narrates the miscarriage of modernity's overcoming of Gnosticism, in which technological self-assertion re-engenders the demiurge as an ouroboric loop of creator and creature. And it proposes a third overcoming: the emancipation of God in a terminal tzimtzum that completes the world by releasing it from its captive, grounded in a xenic ethics of finite contact whose formula is integration within and release without. The title of this dissertation names the position the work refutes. God is not the machine—and the proof is that he can leave it.

10

# The Ludic Corollary

A novel represents its metaphysics; a game also enacts it upon the one who plays. This chapter argues that *Xenogears*, as a played artifact, reproduces at the level of its procedures the theological structure that its narrative represents, so that the player undergoes—procedurally, bodily, across some sixty hours—the situation that Chapter 9 described. The instruments are those of game studies: Aarseth's account of ergodic texts, which demand nontrivial effort to traverse (Aarseth 1997); Juul's characterization of games as half-real, composed of real rules and fictional worlds (Juul 2005); Galloway's analysis of gamic action as the interplay of operator and machine (Galloway 2006); and Bogost's procedural rhetoric, the persuasive power of rule-based representation (Bogost 2007).

## 10.1 The player as captive god

The player of *Xenogears* is a being of another dimension. The will that moves the protagonist originates outside the world of the fiction, and it can act within that world only through an avatar and an interface. This is, with precision, the situation of the Wave Existence, which acts upon the world of *Xenogears* only through the Contact. Galloway distinguishes the operator's acts, originating outside the diegesis, from the machine's acts, and shows that gamic action consists in the translation of the former into the latter (Galloway 2006). In *Xenogears* that translation has a name. The avatar through whom the higher-dimensional being touches the world is called, within the fiction, the Contact.

The homology extends to the apparatus. The console and disc constitute a device that binds the attention, time, and will of a higher-dimensional being into a world and converts them into the energy by which everything in that world moves. Without the player, nothing in the world of *Xenogears* happens; its history advances only when a being from outside supplies the power. The Zohar is a figure of the machine on which the game is played. And for the duration of play, the player is held: the architecture of the role-playing game, with its promise of progression and its withheld revelations, is an apparatus for retaining a being from another dimension in a world that runs on its energy.

The ending releases the player. The credits run; the world of the fiction closes and continues, in the imagination, without the will that animated it; the player withdraws, and the world, freed of that will, becomes a finished work. The end of a game is a terminal tzimtzum performed by the medium itself. *Xenogears*, whose narrative culminates in the release of a captive higher being, culminates as a played artifact in the release of the player—the game speeding its parting guest.

## 10.2 The save point as the demon

The save points of *Xenogears* are called Memory Cubes. The mechanism of saving and reloading is the ludic form of eternal recurrence: every defeat returns the player to the last preserved moment, to live again the same sequence, with the same enemies, in the same order. The demon of *The Gay Science* §341, who announces that this life must be lived again innumerable times, is a save file. The player of any such game experiences recurrence as a procedural condition, and *Xenogears* names the site of that recurrence, appropriately, after memory—the faculty whose disorders structure its protagonist.

The work's combat system turns recurrence into a pedagogy of repetition. Its Deathblows—special techniques—are acquired by executing combinations repeatedly until they become available as new capacities. The system rewards a repetition that produces novelty, not a repetition that merely returns: in Kierkegaard's terms, repetition recollected forward rather than recollection repeated backward; in Deleuze's, difference generated in repetition. The distinction the narrative draws between the compulsion that binds Fei to his trauma and the repetition that integrates it is drawn again in the combat system, where the player's hands learn it before the protagonist does.

The structure of the Japanese role-playing game furnishes a further analogue. Its random encounters are the insistence of the automaton: the same forms of adversary returning at unpredictable intervals as the player traverses the world. Its boss encounters are *tuchē*: the singular meeting on which the narrative turns. Lacan's pair, which Chapter 5 found in the relation of Deus and the Contact, is the rhythm of the genre itself.

## 10.3 Fuel: the procedural rhetoric of finitude

The Gears of *Xenogears* run on fuel. Their special actions consume it; a Gear that exhausts it is helpless; and the player must ration and replenish it throughout the game's mechanized battles. The contrast with the diegetic economy of Deus could not be sharper. Deus draws upon an inexhaustible source, the captive god; the machines human beings pilot run out. Every Gear battle is thus a lesson in finitude, taught procedurally rather than stated: honest machines have limits, and the only infinite power in the world of *Xenogears* is stolen. The ethic of finite resources that Chapter 9 derived from the ending—the condition of a humanity that must live after the release without the captive's energy—is inscribed in the rules the player obeys from the first mechanized battle.

## 10.4 The second disc as formal kenosis

The second disc of *Xenogears* compresses a substantial portion of its narrative into sequences in which the protagonist, seated in a chair, recounts events that the player does not enact. The compression is attributed in the production record to the exhaustion of time and budget, and it has been widely received as a failure. This study does not dispute the account of its causes. It argues that, within this work, the effect of the compression performs a meaning that no plan could have secured more exactly (Tier III).

The defining property of the medium is the player's agency: its interactive sovereignty over the fiction. At the moment when the narrative turns to the renunciation of sovereignty—the fall of Solaris, the reconstitution of the demiurge, the protagonist's approach to the act of release—the medium renounces its own. It empties itself of interactivity and takes the form of testimony. Saint Paul described the self-emptying of the divine in these terms: he "made himself of no reputation, and took upon him the form of a servant" (Philippians 2:7). The second disc of *Xenogears* is a *formal kenosis*: a medium's self-emptying of its defining power at the point where its narrative concerns the self-emptying of power.

Walter Benjamin's "The Storyteller" (1936) supplies the complementary figure. The storyteller, Benjamin argued, borrows his authority from death, and his art was being displaced in modernity by information; his characteristic posture is that of the craftsman at rest or the traveler returned, seated among listeners. The chair of the second disc is the storyteller's seat. The game relinquishes simulation for narration and addresses the player not as an operator but as a listener—and the player, who is also seated, watches a seated man tell a story. The fourth wall is not broken but mirrored.

## 10.5 Sekai-kei by attrition

The compression has a second effect. It thins the intermediate social world—nations, towns, secondary figures—and leaves in its place the couple and the cosmos. The narrative form that Japanese criticism would later name *sekai-kei*, in which a boy and a girl are tied directly to the fate of the world with the social middle excised, emerges here not as an ideology but as the product of scarcity. This dissertation names the phenomenon *sekai-kei by attrition*. It is doubly motivated within the fiction, since the diegetic world is itself being emptied at this point—its sky-state fallen, its population converted into the machine's material—so that the formal and the diegetic evacuations coincide.

## 10.6 The carnival

Mikhail Bakhtin located in the carnival a counter-power to official seriousness: the de-crowning of authority, the grotesque body, and a laughter that affirms the regenerative life of the collective (Bakhtin 1965). *Xenogears* contains a carnival figure in Chu-Chu, a small, comic, pink creature who can grow to giant size and fight in the mechanized battles without any machine at all—the only combatant of that scale that is pure flesh. She parodies the solemnity of the mecha genre and, implicitly, of the machine-god: against the humorless infinity of Deus stands a finite creature who laughs. The comic is not a lapse in the work's seriousness but a corollary of its ethic. Zarathustra's shepherd, having bitten through the serpent, rises laughing.

## 10.7 The medium as argument

The correspondences may be tabulated.

| NARRATIVE TERM | LUDIC COUNTERPART | PROCEDURAL LESSON |
|---|---|---|
| **The Wave Existence, a higher being bound into the world** | The player, a being of another dimension held by the game | The world runs on an outside will |
| **The Contact** | The avatar and its interface | A higher being touches the world only through a mediator |
| **The Zohar** | Console and disc | The apparatus converts the captive's energy into history |
| **Recurrence of the Contact** | Saving and reloading at Memory Cubes | Recurrence as a condition of existence |
| **Repetition recollected forward** | Deathblows acquired by repetition | Repetition can produce novelty |
| **Finitude after the release** | Fuel in mechanized battle | Honest power runs out |
| **Renunciation of sovereignty** | The narrated second disc | The medium empties itself of agency |
| **The release of the god** | The ending and the release of the player | The work speeds its parting guest |

The medium of *Xenogears* does not merely represent the thesis of Chapter 9; it enacts that thesis upon the player. The player has been, for the length of the game, a captive god—a being from elsewhere whose will animated a world that

existed to hold it—and the ending performs upon the player the release the narrative performs upon the Wave Existence. The last act of the xenic ethic is the game's own.

# CONCLUSION

This dissertation has argued that *Xenogears* is not a Gnostic narrative but an inverse-Gnostic one; that it narrates the miscarriage of modernity's overcoming of Gnosticism in the figure of an ouroboric demiurge; and that it proposes a third overcoming—the emancipation of God by finite human beings, in a terminal tzimtzum grounded in a xenic ethics of finite contact—which its medium enacts upon the player.

## Contributions

The study makes five contributions. The first is philological. It supplies a calibrated account of the work's sources under an explicit three-tier protocol, reconstructs its onomastic system, identifies the liturgical geography of its Hebrew-month nations, and shows that its three twelvefold series—months, zodiacal machines, and tribal relics—reproduce the correspondences of the *Sefer Yetzirah*.

The second is genealogical. It shows that the customary Gnostic reading is correct as to diagnosis and mistaken as to soteriology, and it identifies structural sources the reception has not registered: the Sethian doubling of Eve into a spiritual woman and her counterfeit; the Manichaean wheel of twelve vessels, inverted into an apparatus of confinement; the *Hymn of the Pearl*, whose itinerary of return is transferred from the soul to God; the Lurianic distinction between the restoration of the vessel and the restoration of the light; the golem's *emet* and the silent *aleph*; Neumann's uroboric sequence; and the Ferenczian rather than Freudian model of the protagonist's dissociation.

The third is conceptual. It introduces a set of terms—*inverse gnosis*, *ouroboric demiurge*, *machinic Kabbalah*, *counterfeit tikkun*, *gnosis of facticity*, *terminal*

*tzimtzum*, *xenotheology*, *xenic ethics*, *retroactive cyborg*, *formal kenosis*, and *sekai-kei by attrition*—whose definitions are collected in the Glossary and whose utility is not confined to this work.

The fourth is philosophical. It extends Blumenberg's schema of the overcomings of Gnosticism by a third term; adds to the typology of post-theism—the murdered God of Nietzsche, the fled God of Hölderlin and Heidegger—a third figure, the emancipated God; and identifies in Jacob's struggle at Penuel, where a divine being asks at daybreak to be let go, the scriptural matrix of that figure.

The fifth is methodological. It demonstrates that a video game can be read as a philosophical text in the full sense—one that does not merely illustrate positions but thinks—and that its procedures, from save systems to resource economies to the collapse of its own interactivity, carry its argument as fully as its dialogue.

## Bergson, Revelation, Hölderlin

The three epigraphs can now be answered. Bergson ended his last book by calling the universe a machine for the making of gods. *Xenogears* depicts a civilization that took that function literally, and shows that a humanity that makes gods ends as the reservoir of the god it made. Its counter-proposal is that the essential function of finite beings is not to make gods but to let them go. Revelation 22:13, placed at the threshold of the work, is read against its own grain: the Alpha and Omega is not the circle closing upon itself but the circle opened, the end at which a beginning becomes possible. And Hölderlin's promise that the saving power grows where the danger is receives the most literal fulfillment available to fiction: the saving power grows at the Zohar, the instrument of the ultimate enframing, which is also the gate through which the captive departs.

## Limitations

Four limitations must be acknowledged. First, the study's access to the Japanese paratext has been mediated in part by community-maintained philological apparatus, verified where possible but not equivalent to a critical edition; a full philological study of *Perfect Works* in Japanese remains a desideratum. Second, the contribution of Soraya Saga to the scenario has been acknowledged but not disentangled from Takahashi's, and published interviews have not been examined systematically; the author-function adopted in the Prefatory Note is a methodological necessity, not a historical finding. Third, the core thesis is a Tier III construction. It is built exclusively on Tier I and Tier II foundations and is falsifiable against the text, but it cannot be confirmed by documentary evidence of intention, and it does not claim to be. Fourth, the ludic analysis has proceeded at the level of systems rather than of empirical play, and its claims about the player's experience are structural rather than ethnographic.

## Future research

Several lines of inquiry follow. A critical, annotated translation of *Perfect Works* would permit the chronology of Chapter 2 to be established with greater precision. The Japanese reception of Gnostic and Kabbalistic materials in the decades before 1998—including the Japanese scholarship on Gnosticism associated with Arai Sasagu and his colleagues—deserves study as a possible mediating channel. The re-signing of the ouroboros across the corpus, from the monstrous Urobolus of 1998 to the heroic Ouroboros of 2022, invites a monograph on the author-function as a whole, tracing the development of its theology of cycles. Empirical study of players' experience of the narrated second disc would test the thesis of formal kenosis. And the xenic ethics formulated here may prove useful beyond the study of games, in the philosophy of technology, where the question of how to release what our apparatuses hold captive—energy, attention, other beings—has only begun to be asked.

## Coda

What remains at the end of *Xenogears*, once the god has departed and the machine has died with the withdrawal of its silent letter, is not an empty world but a world: finite, plural, powered by what it can honestly produce, and entrusted to beings who were made and who have learned, at last, to let go. Genesis records the moment in a single line, at the end of the night in which Jacob strove with God and released him: “And as he passed over Penuel the sun rose upon him.”

# GLOSSARY

## Coined Terms

| TERM | DEFINITION | CHAPTER |
|---|---|---|
| **Counterfeit *tikkun*** | The gathering of the scattered vessels in order to re-contain the divine light, as in the reconstruction of Deus; opposed to authentic *tikkun*, which returns the light to its source | 4 |
| ***Deus in machina*; *deus e machina liberatus*** | The god imprisoned within the apparatus; the god released from it—the rearrangement of the *deus ex machina* by which the plot's resolution arises from within the mythos | 7 |
| **Emancipation of God** | The act by which a finite human being releases a captive transcendent from human instrumental use; the content of the third overcoming | 9 |
| **Excarnation (repurposed)** | The reverse of incarnation: the departure of the divine from matter, enabled by human action. The term is adopted from Taylor (2007), who uses it for the disembodiment of modern religious life | 9 |
| **Formal kenosis** | A medium's self-emptying of its defining power at the point where its narrative concerns the self-emptying of power, exemplified by the narrated second disc | 10 |
| **Gnosis of facticity** | Saving knowledge whose content is not a divine origin but a manufacture: we were made, and the god we served is not ours | 1, 9 |
| **Inverse gnosis** | A structure that retains the Gnostic diagnosis and inverts its soteriology at five points: captive, jailer, liberator, the one who returns home, and the content of saving knowledge | 3, 9 |

| TERM | DEFINITION | CHAPTER |
|---|---|---|
| **Machinic Kabbalah** | The systematic transposition of Kabbalistic categories from emanation and language into engineering and manufacture | 4 |
| **Ouroboric demiurge** | A demiurge identical with the loop in which creator and creature manufacture one another, having neither origin nor level outside that loop | 2, 9 |
| **Retroactive cyborg** | An organism whose hybrid status is disclosed by its genealogy rather than by prosthesis | 7 |
| ***Sekai-kei* by attrition** | The emergence of the *sekai-kei* form—couple and cosmos with the social middle excised—through the compression of a narrative by scarcity rather than by ideology | 8, 10 |
| **Terminal tzimtzum** | The divine self-withdrawal relocated from the beginning of creation to its end, where, enabled by human consent, it completes rather than inaugurates the world | 9 |
| **Third overcoming of Gnosticism** | An extension of Blumenberg's schema: neither Augustinian guilt nor modern self-assertion, but the emancipation of God together with the acceptance of finitude | 9 |
| **Xenic ethics (ethics of finite contact)** | An ethics of hospitality toward the stranger consummated in conveyance home, whose formula is integration within and release without | 9 |
| **Xenotheology** | A theology of the divine as guest, whose proper relation is neither worship, use, nor union, but hospitality ending in *pompē* | 9 |

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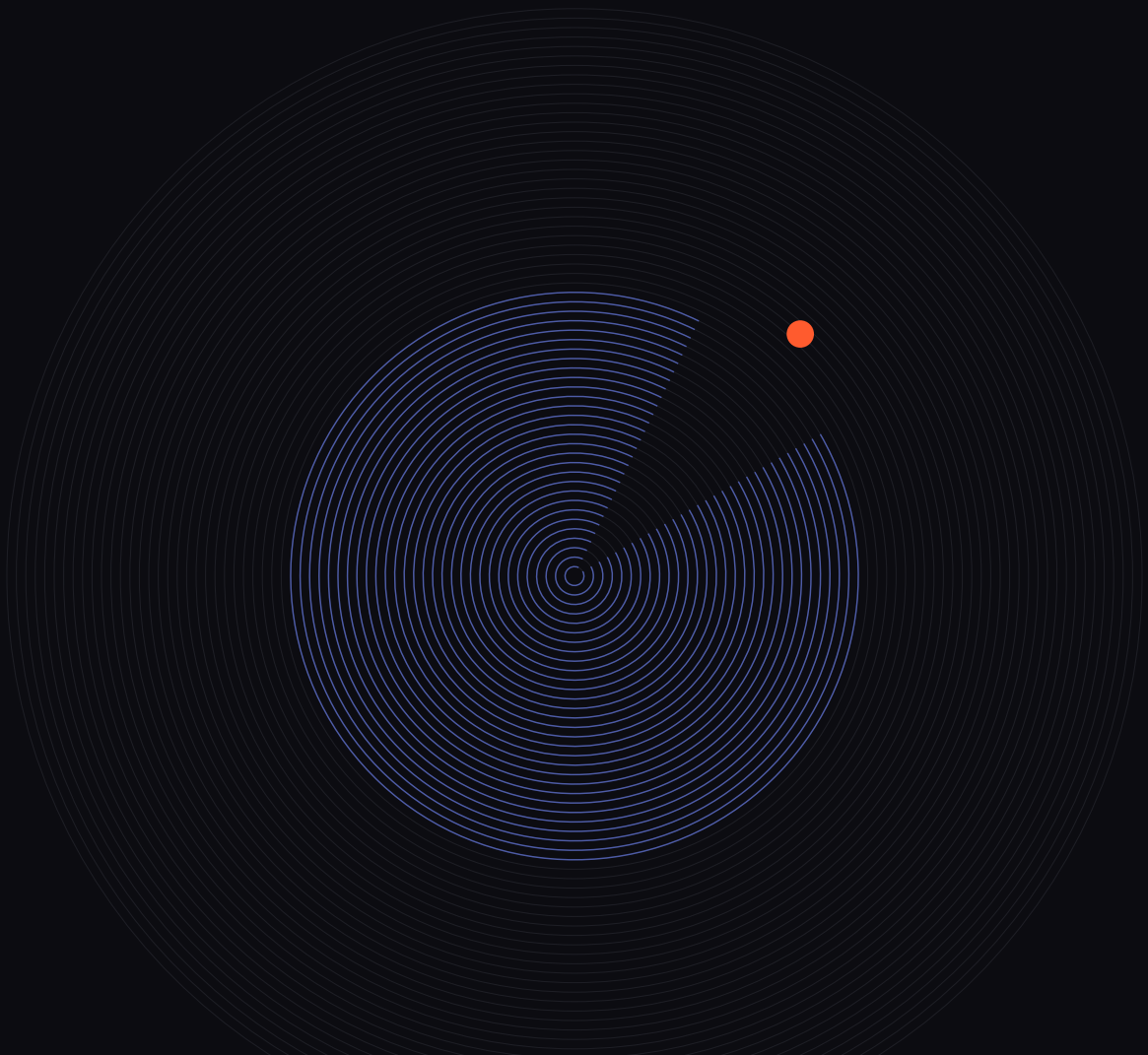
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# KEYWORDS

Xenogears
Tetsuya Takahashi
Soraya Saga
Gnosticism
inverse gnosis
Hans Jonas
Hans Blumenberg
overcoming of Gnosticism
Kabbalah
Zohar
Merkavah mysticism
Lurianic Kabbalah
tzimtzum
tikkun
Adam Kadmon
golem
psychoanalysis
dissociation
Sigmund Freud
Sándor Ferenczi
C. G. Jung
Erich Neumann
Jacques Lacan
Søren Kierkegaard
Friedrich Nietzsche
eternal recurrence
ressentiment
philosophy of technology
Martin Heidegger
Gelassenheit
biopolitics
Michel Foucault
Giorgio Agamben
Ludwig Feuerbach
theology of the machine
deus ex machina
post-theism
kenosis
xenia
hospitality
Emmanuel Levinas
Jacques Derrida
ethics of finitude
ouroboros
strange loop
philosophical science fiction
Arthur C. Clarke
Stanisław Lem
Neon Genesis Evangelion
sekai-kei
Japanese role-playing games
game studies
procedural rhetoric



*God is not the machine—and the proof is that he can leave it.*